

Green Extractivism in Bolivia: the discursive strategies of the MAS party

A longitudinal analysis of framing strategies in
government programmes (2005-2020)

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SUMMARY

In 2005, the *Movimiento al Socialismo* (MAS) party ascended the Bolivian government by bringing its leader Evo Morales to the presidential elections, and secured victory in every subsequent general election (Cunha Filho, 2023). The MAS governance ushered in significant transformations, including the nationalisation of key sectors, the expansion of Indigenous and environmental rights, and a sharp break from prior neoliberal policies (Uharte Pozas, 2017). However, growing tensions emerged as the party's reliance on resource extraction increasingly conflicted with its foundational Indigenous and environmental commitments (Anthias, 2017).

This thesis draws on the concept of Green Extractivism as its theoretical framework to analyse how MAS strategically frames its reliance on extractive activities, with a focus on environmental justifications, to legitimise them, and how these framings have evolved across mandates. The investigation on this matter was conducted using a mixed qualitative-quantitative content analysis of MAS's government programmes from 2005 to 2020, organising all frame types into (sub-)categories and measuring their frequencies in % coverage.

The findings reveal a multifaceted discursive strategy. Economic justifications are the most varied and prominent, portraying extraction as key to productivity, industrialisation, growth, national revenue generation, technological innovation, employment, prosperity and competitiveness. Political framings emphasise sovereignty, anti-imperialism, international standing and national pride as arguments to justify extraction, while social framings underline the role of extraction in improving the Bolivians' quality of life, enhancing equity through redistribution and fostering inclusion. Lastly, environmental justifications, though the least salient, were consistently mobilised. They present resource extraction as both environmentally responsible and environmentally beneficial. While the first one contributes to legitimising the expanding frontiers of the party's extractive activities, the second one goes beyond the compatibility narrative to present extraction (particularly of lithium) as even beneficial and necessary for climate change mitigation. These environmental narratives clearly align with the logic of Green Extractivism as defined by Dunlap et al. (2024).

Overall, MAS shifted from revolutionary nationalist rhetoric to pragmatic developmentalism, with environmental framings selectively emphasised or downplayed depending on the political context. These findings confirm that MAS attempts to reconcile extractivism with environmental concerns through a dynamic and strategic mix of legitimising narratives.

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LIST OF ACRONYMS

CPE	Constitución Política del Estado (Political Constitution of the State)
EDC	Ecological Distribution Conflict
GDP	Gross Domestic Product
GHG	Greenhouse Gas
GTL	Gas-To-Liquids
IDH	Impuesto Directo a los Hidrocarburos (Direct Tax on Hydrocarbons)
ILO	International Labour Organization
IMF	International Monetary Funds
IPSP	Instrumento Político por la Soberanía de los Pueblos (Political Instrument for the Sovereignty of the Peoples)
MAS	Movimiento Al Socialismo (Movement Toward Socialism)
MESCP	Modelo Económico Social Comunitario Productivo (Economic Social Communitarian Productive Model)
OAS	Organization of American States
US	United States
TIPNIS	Territorio Indígena y Parque Nacional Isiboro-Sécure (Isiboro-Sécure Indigenous Territory and National Park)
YLB	Yacimientos de Litio Bolivianos (Bolivian Lithium Deposits)
YPFB	Yacimientos Petrolíferos Fiscales Bolivianos (Bolivian Fiscal Oil Deposits)

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At the age of eighteen, I spent a year travelling alone in Bolivia. That experience did more than expand my horizons, it awakened a profound passion for political science. While I already had a keen interest in the field, discovering the political developments in Bolivia from the mouth of the local population made it vividly clear that politics was something I needed to understand, question, and engage with on a deeper level. Choosing Bolivia as the focus of my final research was, in many ways, an act of coming full circle. To end my academic path by writing about the political development in the very country that first sparked my vocation is both meaningful and deeply fulfilling.

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1 INTRODUCTION AND PROBLEM STATEMENT

In 2005, the *Movimiento al Socialismo* (MAS) party ascended the Bolivian government by bringing its leader Evo Morales to the presidential elections. Since then, the party has maintained broad political support, securing victory in every subsequent general election (Cunha Filho, 2023). The MAS governance has been marked by far-reaching transformations, including the nationalisation of strategic sectors (e.g. hydrocarbon sector), the institutionalisation of expansive Indigenous and environmental rights, and a decisive rupture with the country's preceding neoliberal regime (Uharte Pozas, 2017). However, despite sustained popularity, tensions have gradually emerged as contradictions within MAS governance were highlighted. Notably, the party's heavy reliance on resource extraction often stands in stark contrast to the very Indigenous and environmental commitments that underpin its political legitimacy (Anthias, 2017).

Such contradictions are emblematic of many governments that emerged during Latin America's "Pink Tide", where left-leaning parties combined progressive, often anti-capitalist, discourse with development models rooted in extractivism (Kingsbury, 2021). While this tension has been acknowledged in the literature, few studies examine in detail how governments manage to legitimise such contradictory governance models and maintain electoral popularity. Moreover, much of the existing research tends to generalise Bolivia's experience alongside other Latin American countries, overlooking the unique political narrative of Bolivia's MAS party (Anthias, 2017). Furthermore, scholarly attention was often centred on the tension between extractivism and Indigenous rights, leaving the tensions with environmental commitments neglected.

This thesis draws on the concept of *Green Extractivism* as its theoretical framework to analyse how the MAS party strategically frames its reliance on extractive activities, particularly through environmental justifications, to legitimise them. Additionally, it investigates how these discursive strategies have evolved across successive mandates, and what this reveals. Specifically, the thesis addresses the following research question:

How does the MAS party strategically frame its reliance on extraction to legitimise such practices, and how have these framings evolved across successive mandates?

To answer this question, the research conducts a qualitative and quantitative analysis of five MAS government programmes, corresponding to each of the party's successful electoral campaigns. The manifestos serve as a database to collect information on the party's rhetoric. Using NVivo software, the manifestos are systematically coded to identify and classify the range of framings mobilised to justify extraction. The coded data are then categorised to enable both quantitative measurement and qualitative interpretation. Building on this, a longitudinal analysis is meant to identify rhetorical evolution and shifts across successive mandates. In parallel, an additional literature review is conducted to contextualise each manifesto within the social, political and economic conditions of its time, providing a basis for interpreting discursive change.

To guide the analysis, four hypotheses are proposed:

1. H1: MAS strategically frames extractive practices in environmental terms to legitimise them, consistent with the concept of Green Extractivism.
2. H2: MAS's framing of the extractive sector has evolved over time and across different mandates.
3. H3: Despite its rhetorical commitment to environmental protection, MAS consistently prioritises extractive activities and the economy.
4. H4: The leadership transition from Evo Morales to Luis Arce is accompanied by a discursive shift in how extractivism and environmentalism are framed.

The thesis proceeds by first situating MAS's extractive model within broader academic debates on extractivism. It then introduces the theoretical framework of Green Extractivism and outlines the methodology employed. The results are presented both chronologically, manifesto by manifesto, and in a final longitudinal analysis. This is followed by a discussion reflecting on the study's limitations. Lastly, the conclusion offers a synthesis of the main insights and a response to the central research question.

2 LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 The MAS party

The *Movimiento al Socialismo* is a unique political formation in Latin America, distinguished by its origins as a bottom-up initiative rooted in rural social movements. It emerged in the 1990s from the *cocalero* unions (coca growers unions) of the Chapare region in Bolivia, a response to both the socio-economic fallout of neoliberal restructuring and the militarised enforcement of US-backed coca eradication policies. MAS began not as a conventional political party, but as a “political instrument” (*instrumento político*) through which marginalised rural groups sought to gain representation in the state apparatus (Anria, 2013). Ideologically, MAS combines elements of anti-imperialism, Indigenous self-representation, and economic nationalism. It articulates a hybrid discourse that blends class and ethnic appeals, reflecting the party’s attempt to build a multiclass, pluriethnic coalition (McKay, 2017).

While its rise must be situated within the broader context of Latin America’s “Pink Tide”, a wave of left-leaning governments that came to power in the early 2000s as a response to the failures of neoliberal policies, Bolivia’s experience is unique. MAS’s trajectory is often misgrouped with that of Venezuela under Hugo Chávez or Ecuador under Rafael Correa. Although Evo Morales is known to be MAS’s charismatic and popular leader, the party’s ascent was primarily characterised by deep ties to organised social movements, particularly in rural areas, while the Ecuadorian and Venezuelan trajectories were driven by a single charismatic leader mobilising a mass base in a top-down fashion (Anria, 2013; McKay, 2017).

2.2 Conceptual Debates around Extractivism

MAS’s economic reliance on extractive activities must be analysed within the broader theoretical frameworks that have emerged to interpret such dynamics. This paper engages with the scholarly literature on extractivism, neo-extractivism, post-extractivism, and pluri-extractivism, situating Bolivia’s experience within these evolving conceptual debates.

Extractivism is conceptualised by Gudynas (2009) as “*un estilo de desarrollo basado en la apropiación de la Naturaleza*” (a style of development based on the appropriation of Nature) (Gudynas, 2009, p.188), referring to extractive activities that involve the large-scale removal

of natural resources, with little to no processing, and are destined for export. Acosta (2013) broadens this view to include activities like farming, fishing, and forestry, arguing that the overexploitation of both renewable and non-renewable resources, along with the labour and fossil fuels involved, is often overlooked. However, Dunlap et al. (2024) critique Gudynas's state-centric approach and Acosta's overly broad definition. Accounting for the long list of diverse authors' contributions to the understanding of the notion of "extractivism", they propose a refined conceptualisation through three statements: (1) extractivism involves the appropriation of resources to render them legible for value creation; (2) it disrupts socioecological reciprocity, potentially leading to ecocide; and (3) it is rooted in broader interconnected political-economic and ideological systems that make such processes possible (Dunlap et al., 2024). They further draw on the Ecological Distribution Conflicts (EDCs) framework, conceptualised by Martínez-Alier as social conflicts that emerge over the unequal distribution of environmental costs and benefits, and Green Grabbing, defined by Fairhead et al. as the appropriation of land under environmental pretexts (Dunlap et al., 2024). These frameworks inform the study of Green Extractivism, developed further in the next section.

Neo-extractivism refers to a form of extractivism linked to the rise of left-leaning governments in the early 2000s, also known as the "Pink Tide" or "Left Turn", which attempted to address socio-economic inequalities of neoliberalism through resource extraction (Kingsbury, 2021). This model, as outlined by Maristella Svampa (2019), a central figure in the study of the framework, marks a shift from traditional extractivism by its integration into progressive government agendas. Neo-extractivism is characterised by the state's dominant role in managing and appropriating resource rents, which are then used to fund redistributive policies and social welfare programmes. However, it remains deeply extractive, prioritising large-scale mining, fossil fuel extraction, and agro-industrial monocultures, often to the detriment of environmental sustainability and local communities (Svampa, 2019). Bolivia's relation to extractivism under MAS typically falls into this framework. The theorist criticises neo-extractivism for its inherent contradictions, particularly its reliance on environmentally destructive practices and its alignment with global capitalist dynamics despite progressive rhetoric.

Post-extractivism, in contrast, emerged as a critique and alternative to (neo)extractivist development models. Alberto Acosta, a central figure in the development of this framework, defines post-extractivism as a call to transition from economies reliant on natural resource

extraction to models that prioritise ecological sustainability, social equity, and diversification (Acosta et al., 2017). Drawing on indigenous principles like Buen Vivir, Acosta emphasises the need to shift societal values away from relentless economic growth and towards harmonious coexistence with nature. He also advocates for reducing resource consumption, fostering local production, and recognising the intrinsic rights of ecosystems. While post-extractivism remains an aspirational framework, it offers a roadmap for addressing the structural inequalities and ecological degradation perpetuated by extractivist economies.

In recent studies about Bolivia's extractivist model, a new framework has emerged: the **pluri-extractivist model**. Anthias (2018), the principal author behind this, critically examines the contradictions of Bolivia's extractive economy and introduces the concept of pluri-extractivism to describe Bolivia's unique development model, where resource extraction is integrated into the state's plurinational Constitution, which at the same time recognises indigenous rights and ecological principles.

3 THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

Green Extractivism is a recent concept that draws on the debates on extractivism and related theoretical frameworks such as addressed in the literature review. For this paper, we draw on the understandings of the framework as provided by Dunlap et al. (2024), adopting a primarily *Political Ecology* analytical lens. Political Ecology as defined by Martínez-Alier (2002) refers to the study of ecological distribution conflicts, focusing on how environmental benefits and burdens are unequally shared across societies, and critically examining the political, economic, and social factors that shape environmental outcomes.

Dunlap et al. (2024) define Green Extractivism through four statements: first, *“it uses socioecological, weather and climate crises to generate new or reinforce existing ‘green’ markets or profit generating activities”*. Secondly, *“it involves the mobilisation of claims of ecological sustainability, ‘carbon neutrality’, and combatting climate change in order to legitimise and rationalize extraction”*. Thirdly, *“it is fundamentally entwined with conventional extractivism”*. Lastly, *“it rests on false assumptions regarding the renewability of ‘resources’, or existences”* (pp. 447-449).

It was mentioned for the first time in 2017 by Dunlap and was then described as “green mining” and conceptualised as the reconciliation between industrial extraction and social and ecological ‘sustainability’ (Dunlap et al., 2024). Further studies focused on the “Lithium Triangle”, a geographic area covering Argentina, Chile and Bolivia that upholds the vast majority of lithium reserves in the world, as fertile ground for developing the concept. Aronoff et al. (2019) and Janubová (2023) interpreted the mining of lithium brines for electric car batteries in the Lithium Triangle in the light of Green Extractivism. They pointed out that these mining activities, although branded as 'green' due to their association with renewable energy, often perpetuate traditional extractive practices that result in environmental degradation, water scarcity, and socio-economic disruptions for local communities, particularly indigenous populations. Aronoff et al. (2019) advocate for a “Green New Deal” that not only transitions to renewable energy but also fundamentally reevaluates consumption patterns, prioritises social justice, and ensures that environmental policies do not come at the expense of vulnerable communities.

Voskoboynik and Andreucci (2022) likewise analysed Green Extractivism in relation to the mining of so-called “transition minerals” (e.g. lithium). Their work explores the discourses that allow such mining to be legitimised and even supported despite its high socioecological costs.

According to the authors, Green Extractivism “... *represents a new phase in the complex relationship between mining and the environment, whereby extraction and valorisation of mineral resources are rendered not only compatible with ‘sustainable development’, but necessary to it and the possibility of a ‘low carbon’ future*” (Voskoboynik and Andreucci, 2022, p.802). Furthermore, Anna Heikkinen (2024) highlights the key contradiction that Green Extractivism addresses: while mining for minerals is intended to support climate action, it often ends up endangering sensitive environments and disrupting the communities that depend on them, thereby worsening the very climate issues it aims to address.

Our primary goal through this research paper is to analyse how MAS attempts to rhetorically reconcile extractivism with environmentalism. Therefore, Green Extractivism provides an ideal framework to look into such dynamic.

4 METHODOLOGY

4.1 Data sources

This paper analyses the government programmes of the *Movimiento al Socialismo* (MAS), spanning from its first electoral victory to its most recent one (2005, 2009, 2014, 2019, and 2020).

Government programmes are political documents that serve as strategic instruments balancing electoral appeal, governance plans, and ideological commitments (Le Pennec, 2024; Nasr, 2024) providing relevant data on MAS's rhetoric and discursive strategies. They present a unified political message designed to appeal to diverse constituencies (Huber, 2022). In the case of MAS, these constituencies include working-class sectors that benefit from resource extraction, indigenous and environmental movements advocating for ecological protection, and international actors concerned with sustainability. Consequently, shifts in emphasis, omissions, and hybrid discourses within these texts provide insights into how MAS strategically adapts its rhetoric to maintain broad political support while navigating structural constraints. Given MAS's historical efforts to reconcile its extractivist development model with a discourse of environmental protection and indigenous rights (Botero & Galeano, 2017), these programmes offer a valuable lens for tracking both continuities and contradictions in the party's positioning.

Additionally, manifestos offer a coherent and standardised format across time, making them particularly well-suited for systematic comparison and tracking discursive shifts across different political mandates. By systematically analysing the party's programmes across multiple electoral cycles, we seek to identify patterns of discursive evolution, moments of heightened or diminished environmental rhetoric, and the various ways in which MAS justifies extractivism.

Lastly, as emphasised by Zúñiga (2018), assessing party programmes requires careful contextualisation. In light of this, each manifesto will be situated within its specific political, social, and economic context, focusing on key developments that preceded its publication. This contextual grounding aims to help identify possible explanations for the discursive shifts observed throughout the analysis. The contextual data presented is drawn from an extensive review of the literature.

4.2 Data analysis

To analyse MAS's five electoral programmes, we employ a thematic content analysis method, which is the most common approach for assessing a party's positioning (Zúñiga, 2018). The analysis is conducted using NVivo, a qualitative data analysis software that facilitates systematic coding and comparison (Wong, 2008). Following the recommendations of Fereday and Muir-Cochrane (2006), we adopt a hybrid thematic content analysis approach, combining deductive and inductive coding. Deductive coding, based on existing literature, establishes an initial set of thematic categories to guide the coding process. Inductive coding is then applied during the coding process to allow new themes or sub-themes to emerge organically, ensuring that the analysis remains open to relevant but unanticipated categories. The analysis follows these steps: (1) a preliminary reading to gain familiarity with the language of the data and to test our initial grid of analysis; (2) a second reading inducting new codes as they emerge; (3) a third reading to reorganise coded material in light of refinements to the typology; and finally (4) a comparative analysis to establish differences and continuities across programmes.

4.3 Grid of analysis

To construct our initial grid of analysis, we draw mainly on the work of Voskoboynik and Andreucci (2022) through the lens of Green Extractivism. Their article analyses the discursive strategies employed by diverse institutional actors of the Lithium Triangle (Chile, Argentina, Bolivia) to justify lithium extraction, emphasising the centrality of discourse in resource governance. They establish three types of justifications:

1. The first type frames lithium extraction as a pathway to economic prosperity, highlighting its potential to drive growth, foster inclusive development, support industrialisation, modernise the economy, and generate employment.
2. The second presents lithium as a tool for reinforcing national sovereignty, integrity, and prosperity in competitive resource geopolitics.
3. The third strategy stresses lithium's key role in climate mitigation, and its environmentally benign extraction process. In that case, lithium is framed as '*sustainable*', '*contemporary*', '*responsible*', '*reflexive*', etc. (Voskoboynik & Andreucci, 2022. pp. 796-800).

Based on a preliminary reading of the five manifestos, we have decided to reorganise the analytical grid into four codes: **economic**, **political**, **environmental**, and **social** categories. While the first three categories are inspired by the three frame types identified in the reference article, the social category is a personal addition based on the preliminary reading. Although there was no direct mention of social justification by Voskoboynik and Andreucci, it appeared to be a common, even central argument in MAS manifestos.

Through the establishment of these fourfold typology, we seek to organise the inductive process. Our goal is to establish a more specific typology, accounting for the variety of framings used by MAS. The four codes identified are to be understood as themes, within which we will organise the categories of framings/justifications we will encounter during the inductive process.

5 RESULTS

Throughout this section, four types of results are presented. First, the final analytical grid developed through the coding process captures the range of arguments MAS employs to justify extractive activities. This is presented in the form of a typology that categorises the various framings used by the party (see 5.1). Second, graphical representations illustrate the thematic distribution of these justificatory arguments in quantitative terms. These graphs allow for a comparison of the frequency of each sub-category expressed in percentage coverage. This means that a sub-category with a coverage of 2.5% represents 2.5% of the total content of the manifesto. Third, descriptions of the content of MAS's framings provide valuable insights into how such framings also qualitatively evolve. Fourth, each section includes a brief overview of the manifesto's environmental content to illustrate how environmental discourse has evolved alongside the extractive agenda. In parallel, each manifesto is preceded by a contextual overview, providing a better means of understanding to follow the evolution of the documents in relation to their contexts.

Before presenting the results, it is important to clarify some details about the coding process. All sentences that frame extractive activities in ways that could serve, either directly or indirectly, to legitimise such practices were coded. We consider here as extractive activities those related to the extraction of natural resources, in particular of hydrocarbons (with an emphasis on natural gas and petroleum), the entire mining sector, and evaporitic resources such as lithium and its derivatives. Furthermore, the coding was applied to entire sentences to preserve semantic coherence. However, a sentence can contain multiple types of justifications. In such cases, the percentage coverage of that sentence is attributed to each sub-category it is assigned to, which means that it can be represented multiple times within the same theme if it fits several of the theme's sub-themes. To prevent certain themes from being overrepresented due to a finer fragmentation into sub-categories, each graph includes a **'theme adjusted measure'** that reflects the total percentage of the category after withdrawing repeated coded sentences. That way, we did not have to choose between either representing correctly the sub-themes' coverage or the theme-level coverage. Fortunately, while the absolute values differ, both measures reflect the exact same patterns of prominence and evolution.

5.1 Typology of justifications

Category	Sub-category	Description	Examples from MAS manifestos (translated from Spanish)
Economic	Growth	Resource extraction as a way to generate economic growth.	<i>“In the short term, the extractive sector remains a pillar of <u>growth</u>, generating conditions for the production of value-added goods (...)”</i> (issued from the 2009 manifesto, p.42)
	Generation of revenues / surplus	Resource extraction as a way to generate revenues / surplus for the state.	<i>“The strategic sectors of hydrocarbons, energy, and mining are the fundamental pillars of Bolivia's economy, as they <u>generate surpluses</u> (...)”</i> (issued from the 2019 manifesto, p.28)
	Productivity	Resource extraction as way to enhance the state's productive apparatus.	<i>“It is necessary and essential to use hydrocarbon resources to improve the quality of life of the population and <u>to reactivate the national productive apparatus</u>. ”</i> (issued from the 2005 manifesto, p.17)
	Industrialisation	Resource extraction as means to develop the industrialisation of various sectors.	<i>“It is necessary to <u>accelerate the industrialisation of our raw materials</u> by promoting projects to change the energy matrix and <u>to industrialise our evaporite and hydrocarbon resources</u>, in order to establish a basic industry in the country, (...)”</i> (issued from the 2020 manifesto, p.18)
	Diversification	Resource extraction as a way to diversify the state's economy.	<i>“In the short term, the extractive sector remains a pillar of growth, (...), thereby <u>achieving diversification</u> of the productive matrix. ”</i> (issued from the 2009 manifesto, p.42)
	Innovation / Technology	Resource extraction enables innovation and technology.	<i>“The production of metallic lithium will make it possible to <u>manufacture high-tech lithium batteries</u> to supply the global market for the mass electronics industry.”</i> (issued from the 2009 manifesto, p.86)
	Employment	Resource extraction as a way to foster employment	<i>“The industrialisation of lithium will exponentially boost the regional and national economy, <u>create thousands of jobs</u>, and generate a development hub in one of the country's poorest departments. ”</i> (issued from the 2009 manifesto, p.86)
	Prosperity / Security	Resource extraction reinforces the state's economic security, prosperity and sustainability.	<i>“In order to <u>avoid an economic crisis</u> resulting from neoliberal measures, it is necessary to accelerate the industrialisation of our raw materials. ”</i> (issued from the 2020 manifesto, p.18)
	Competitiveness	Resource extraction as a way to enhance the economy's competitiveness.	<i>“In this context, <u>Bolivian gas has demonstrated its price competitiveness</u> compared to LNG imported from overseas by these countries. This competitiveness is reflected in the increase in gas volumes sent to Brazil, from 24.6 MMcfd to 36.8 MMcfd, and to Argentina, from 4.6 MMcfd to 16.3 MMcfd. ”</i> (issued from the 2014 manifesto, p.46)
Social	Equity / Redistribution	Revenues from extraction fund social programmes that generate major equity and address socioeconomic inequalities.	<i>“The State appropriates the surpluses from strategic sectors (...). At the same time, the State uses part of these <u>surpluses for social policies and income redistribution</u>, (...)”</i> (issued from the 2014 manifesto, p.19)

	Quality of life	Resource extraction contributes to an elevation of the Bolivians' quality of life.	<i>"It is necessary and essential to use hydrocarbon resources to <u>improve the quality of life of the population</u> (...)." (issued from the 2005 manifesto, p.17)</i>
	Inclusivity	Resource extraction enables greater inclusion.	<i>"Bolivia's great challenge is to build a more equitable society that harnesses its natural resources so that <u>the men and women</u> who inhabit the nation's territory can live with dignity, free from need, <u>without discrimination, and in harmony</u>." (issued from the 2009 manifesto, p.36)</i>
Political	Sovereignty	Resource extraction as a way for Bolivia to enhance its sovereignty and gain greater control over its own lands	<i>"In response to this situation, a deep national awareness has emerged regarding the need to <u>reclaim ownership of our hydrocarbons and to regain control and direction of this strategic sector so that it serves national interests</u>." (issued from the 2005 manifesto, p.14)</i>
	Anti-imperialism	Resource extraction as a tool to resist foreign economic domination and as symbol of national independence.	<i>"The nationalisation of hydrocarbons, mining, electricity, telecommunications, and other sectors has allowed the State to take ownership of resources that were <u>previously taken by transnational corporations</u> and allocate them toward building a productive and industrialised economy." (issued from the 2014 manifesto, p.11)</i>
	International / Regional integration / standing	Resource extraction as a means for regional and international integration, as well as regional and international standing.	<i>"The importance and magnitude of our reserves, along with our geographic position, will not only allow us to <u>participate in these integration processes</u> but also to <u>assume an essential and leading role</u>—one that must be transformed into strong regional support for the refounding and strengthening of YPFB." (issued from the 2005 manifesto, p.17)</i>
	National pride	Resource extraction generates a sentiment of national pride.	<i>"The people clearly understand that if these vast riches do not return to our hands, Bolivia would be condemned to remain <u>a beggar nation, scorned</u> in the international context." (issued from the 2005 manifesto, p.14)</i>
Environ-mental	Necessary to sustainability / combat climate change	Resource extraction as necessary to enable the transition to a sustainable society and to combat climate change.	<i>"With this, Bolivia will become an important hub for clean energy generation and will <u>contribute to reducing dependence on petroleum-based energy sources, helping to lower greenhouse gas emissions and mitigate the effects of climate change resulting from global warming</u>." (issued from the 2009 manifesto, p.86)</i>
	Eco-responsibility	Resource extraction is managed responsibly and is respectful toward the environment.	<i>"In other words, to move from a mining sector that exports concentrated minerals to becoming a metallurgical mining country capable of developing its iron and steel industry <u>while protecting the environment</u>." (issued from the 2009 manifesto, p.21)</i>

5.2 MAS 2005 manifesto

5.2.1 1980-2005 context

Between the mid-1980s and the early 2000s, Bolivia experienced two decades of neoliberal governance characterised by structural adjustment policies, the privatisation of natural resource extraction and export-oriented growth. These reforms, promoted by international financial institutions like the IMF and World Bank, aimed to stabilise hyperinflation and attract foreign investment, but came at a significant social cost. The promise of economic growth never materialised for the majority, leading to widespread inequality and disenfranchisement. Social unrest intensified during the 1990s and early 2000s, culminating in major uprisings such as the multiple ‘water wars’ (Bueno & Datta, 2011). In particular, the 2000 Cochabamba Water War became a symbol of resistance against neoliberal privatisation. Mass mobilisations opposed a water concession to a foreign corporation (*Aguas del Tunari* consortium) that resulted in sharply increased water tariffs, even for previously self-managed community systems, and successfully forced the government to cancel the deal (Assies, 2003).

Mass protests continued in 2003 with the first Gas War, centred on the government’s plan to export natural gas to the US via Chile, a move seen as both economically unjust and historically insensitive given Bolivia’s loss of coastal territory to Chile in the 19th century. Perreault (2008) notes that the uprising, led by a coalition of Aymara peasants from El Alto and other grassroots groups, reflected longstanding demands for national control over natural resources and the rejection of neoliberal extractivism. The state’s militarised response to the protests, which caused over 70 deaths, intensified public outrage and ultimately forced the resignation of President Sánchez de Lozada. Similar mass mobilisations in May and June of 2005 compelled his successor, Carlos Mesa, to step down as well, and to call for new elections. These movements brought to the fore long-standing grievances rooted in colonial marginalisation, especially among the indigenous majority (Anria, 2013).

By 2005, amid social unrest, economic crisis and political instability, Morales campaigned against the discredited neoliberal elite. In the December 2005 election, Morales won a historic 53.7% of the vote, bringing MAS to power and becoming Bolivia’s first Indigenous president and the first to win an outright majority from the state’s modern electoral history (Bueno & Datta, 2011).

5.2.2 Content analysis

The 2005 MAS government programme is structured as a wide-ranging response to what it identifies as the profound economic, political, and social crises resulting from 20 years of neoliberalism in Bolivia. Under the slogan “*Por una Bolivia Digna, Soberana y Productiva para Vivir Bien*” (For a Dignified, Sovereign and Productive Bolivia to Live Well), the document lays out a vision for radical transformation of the state, economy, and society. It opens with a forceful critique of neoliberal reforms, particularly the surrender of control over natural resources to transnational corporations, the deepening of a dual economy in which foreign capital flourishes while local producers struggle, and the privatisation of public services and strategic state enterprises through *capitalización*. These policies, MAS argues, have entrenched poverty, exclusion, and inequality. In response, MAS proposes the creation of a “*Nuevo Modelo Económico de reciprocidad y redistribución*”, centred on a *matriz productiva*, a new productive matrix that emphasises state leadership, local participation, and strategic industrialisation.

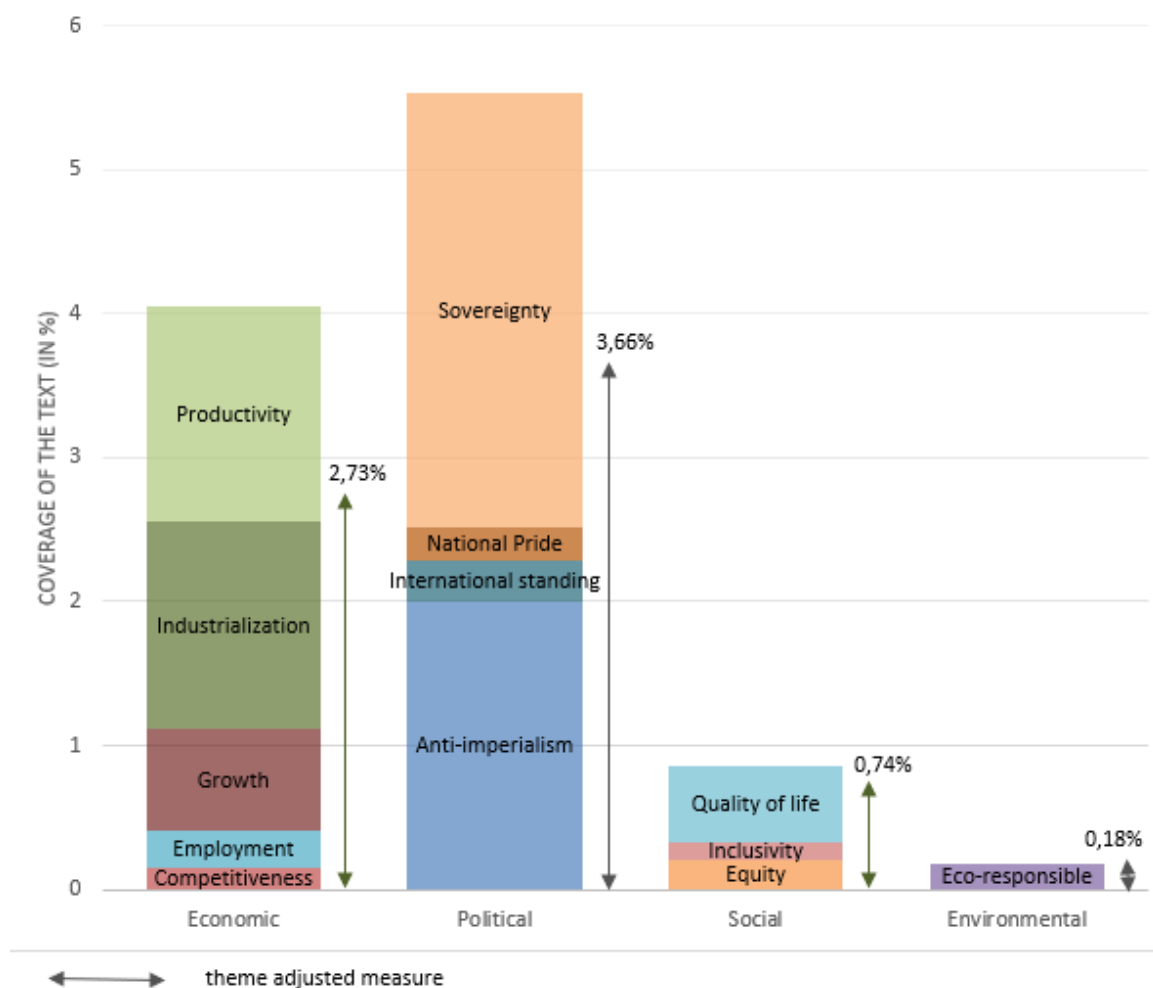


Figure 1: justifications' repartition of the 2005 MAS government programme

The programme presents hydrocarbons and mining as the two main pillars of this productive matrix, aimed at transforming Bolivia into a productive state. The productivity argument is the most represented within the economic theme, accounting for 1.5%¹ coverage of the text, followed by the industrialisation argument that accounts for 1.44% coverage. These two themes are closely interlinked, with industrialisation portrayed as both a necessary condition and ultimate goal of building a robust productive matrix. The party's *Plan Maestro* consists in reorienting the extractive sector to satisfy the internal demands first, then to export processed hydrocarbons with added value through industrialisation. Other economic justifications, while present, are less prominent: economic growth is mentioned in 0.7% of the text, framed as a consequence of industrial development and productive reinvestment; employment accounts for 0.26%, seen as a secondary benefit of the productive transformation; and competitiveness is mentioned only twice (0.15%), in relation to the belief that the development of the extractive sectors will enhance the competitiveness of Bolivian industry.

More significantly, extractive activities, particularly hydrocarbons, are imbued with symbolic and political meaning. Justifications related to sovereignty constitute the most prominent narrative (3.02%), followed by anti-imperialism (2%). The nationalisation of gas and oil is framed not merely as a policy choice but as a *historic imperative*, indispensable for restoring Bolivia's dignity and reclaiming control over its destiny. Moreover, MAS insists on the *effective* nationalisation of the hydrocarbon sector, extending beyond formal ownership to include operational control. Assigning the state-owned company *Yacimientos Petrolíferos Fiscales Bolivianos* (YPFB) a central role in extraction, processing, and commercialisation would reduce Bolivia's dependence on foreign capital and technology. This process is also linked to broader narratives of national pride (0.22%) and international standing (0.29%). The former underscores the reclamation of dignity through sovereign control of resources, while the latter argues that successful management and industrialisation of natural wealth will elevate Bolivia's status and facilitate regional integration.

Social justifications for extractive activities are also present, albeit less emphasised. The most salient is the improvement of the population's quality of life (0.53%) through the new management model of resource exploitation. This is followed by references to equity (0.21%),

¹ A table presenting the coverage percentages for all five manifestos is available in Annex A

the idea that resource wealth will benefit the entire population, although specific redistributive policies are not yet elaborated.

Notably, the environmental theme appears twice (0.18%), framed as the need to define a model of exploitation that is responsible and future-oriented within the new economic paradigm (eco-responsibility).

5.2.3 Environmental content

The MAS programme also contains a dedicated section on environment, biodiversity, and natural resources, revealing a certain environmental consciousness. The programme outlines a comprehensive and socially inclusive approach, emphasising decentralised governance, respect for traditional knowledge, ecological responsibility, and the creation of institutional frameworks to safeguard natural resources. For example, the government commits not to permit hydrocarbon or mining exploitation in protected areas and to ban on harmful agrochemical and transgenic inputs. It proposes the creation of an *Instituto Nacional de Biodiversidad* and the development of regulations for biodiversity conservation. Measures to combat deforestation, promote reforestation, and ensure sustainable forestry are also emphasised. In total, the environmental theme covers 2.65% of the entire text, while the extractive theme covers 8.17% of the text (these data are referred to later in graph 7).

5.3 MAS 2009 Manifesto

5.3.1 2006-2009 context

Following Morales' 2005 election, the MAS government implemented a model of resource nationalism, particularly focusing on the hydrocarbon sector. After creating the *impuesto directo a los hidrocarburos* (IDH), namely the direct tax on hydrocarbons, the government nationalised oil and gas sectors through Supreme Decree 28701. This move required foreign companies to renegotiate contracts, ensuring that the state-owned company YPFB held a majority stake in all operations. From 2006 to 2008, YPFB profits from exploration and exploitation contracts rose from \$1.55 to \$2.7 billion. These revenues were directed toward social programmes, including non-contributory pensions *Renta Dignidad* and educational incentives, such as *Bono Juancito Pinto*, and reinvested into the national economy, contributing to poverty reduction and economic growth (Aresti, 2016; ILO, 2016).

Building on this developmentalist agenda, Morales declared lithium a strategic resource and a national priority in 2008, launching a fully state-owned lithium industrialisation project in the *Salar de Uyuni* (Sanchez-Lopez, 2019). The lithium industrialisation project was structured into three stages: (1) a pilot phase (2008–2012), involving the construction of pilot plants for potassium chloride and lithium carbonate; (2) industrial-scale production, starting in 2012 but delayed; and (3) high-tech manufacturing of battery components, in order to avoid dependence on primary commodities (Janubová, 2023).

Parallel to these economic transformations, MAS prioritised the drafting of a new constitution to redefine Bolivia as a ‘Plurinational State’, marking a landslide transformation of the country’s political and legal framework. The Constituent Assembly aimed at drafting the new constitution convened in 2006. Despite facing opposition from conservative sectors and regional leaders, a draft constitution was completed in late 2007. After final compromise amendments, the Constitution was ultimately approved by a national referendum in January 2009, laying the groundwork for the December 2009 elections (Centellas, 2013). The *Constitución Política del Estado* acknowledges the existence of 36 distinct Indigenous nations and peoples, granting them broad collective rights such as the right to self-determination (Constitución Política del Estado [CPE], Art. 2) and the use of their own language as official language alongside Spanish (CPE, Art. 5). Indigenous peoples were also given the right to manage, control, and benefit from their territories, and to be consulted through free, prior, and informed consent on matters affecting their lands (CPE, Art. 30). These provisions not only reversed centuries of exclusion but aimed to decolonise the state and embed indigenous worldviews, such as the *Vivir Bien* (Living Well), an Andean philosophy advocating harmony between humans and nature, communal well-being, and ecological equilibrium (Gudynas & Acosta, 2011).

The December 2009 general elections took place in a context of relative political stability and sustained economic growth, underpinned by high commodity prices and MAS’s redistributive policies. Morales campaigned on having fulfilled key promises: constitutional reform, economic inclusion, and indigenous empowerment. According to the *Tribunal Supremo Electoral* ², the latter was re-elected with 64.2% of the vote and the party secured a two-thirds supermajority in both chambers of Bolivia’s Legislative Assembly.

² Tribunal Supremo Electoral. (n.d.). *Elecciones generales 2009*. <https://www.oep.org.bo/procesos-electorales-y-consultas/elecciones-generales/elecciones-generales-2009/>

5.3.2 Content analysis

The 2009 MAS government programme, titled “*Rumbo a una Bolivia Líder*” (Toward a Leading Bolivia), is framed as a consolidation and deepening of the *Proceso de Cambio* (process of change) launched in 2006. Building on the nationalisations, constitutional reform, and redistributive policies of its first term, MAS now envisions transforming Bolivia into a *País Líder* (leading country) through four foundational pillars: (1) a Plurinational and democratic state; (2) a productive economy; (3) a dignified society; and (4) national sovereignty. The new agenda is ambitious, proposing the “*Gran Salto Industrial*” (Great Industrial Leap), integration infrastructure, expanded public services, and technological independence.

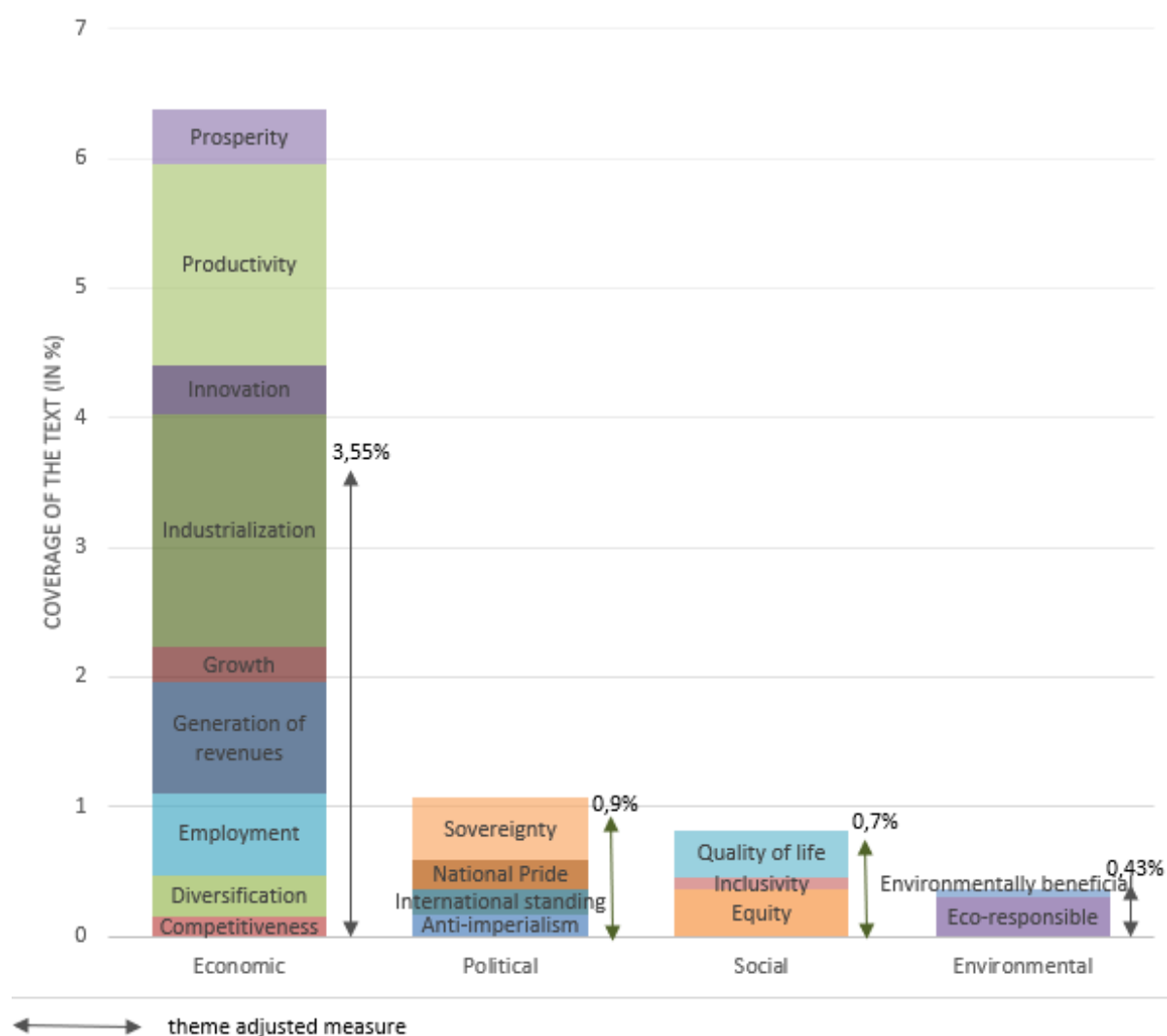


Figure 2: justifications' repartition of the 2009 MAS government programme

Extractive sectors, especially hydrocarbons and mining, remain at the core of the economic strategy. Although sovereignty remains a key justification, it is reframed more economically than politically: sovereignty now refers primarily to state possession/appropriation and

complete control over revenues and surpluses generated by the extractive sector. This shift is underscored by the emergence of a new subcategory, ‘generation of revenues’, which accounts for 0.83% of the text. Arguments based on growth, though less frequent than in the 2005 manifesto (0.27), are more explicitly stated, for example referring directly to how the mining sector contributes to the GDP and presenting economic growth as an end in itself. Productivity (1.54%) and Industrialisation (1.8%) are still the major economic arguments for extraction and are now the most represented throughout the entire text. A new category ‘diversification’ appears with 0.32% coverage, referring to the role of the industrialisation of extractive resources in diversifying the productive apparatus. Under the banner of the *Gran Salto Industrial*, and the country’s entry in *la era satelital*, MAS proposes an extensive list of production and industrialisation projects, including large-scale mining-metallurgical complexes like El Mutún and Corocoro, petrochemical plants, the industrialisation of lithium, and the conversion of natural gas into liquid fuels (Gas-To-Liquids). These are often framed as strategies to break with the primary-exporter model, by creating value-added production. In particular, the industrialisation of lithium carries significant symbolic weight: behind the exploitation and industrialisation plan, MAS envisions manufacturing high-tech lithium batteries for global electronic vehicles, and even the creation of a Bolivian automotive industry powered by locally produced lithium-ion batteries.

New justifications also appear. Economic prosperity (0.42%) emerges to cover arguments referring to the role of extraction in ensuring energy sovereignty and a securing economic stability. Innovation / Technological arguments (0.38%) mostly refer to the new processes and products derived from oil and natural gas in areas such as fertilizers, polymers, diesel, etc, which contribute to the technological development of the state. Employment (0.64%) is more visible than in 2005, related to the scale of MAS’s industrial agenda for 2009-2014, while competitiveness remains marginal (0.15%).

Political arguments decline markedly, with sovereignty (0.48%) and anti-imperialism (0.17%) down from 2005, reflecting the shift from political to economic framing of sovereignty. National pride (0.22%) and international standing (0.20%) remain relatively unchanged, despite the aspirational tone of the “Bolivia líder” title. However, international standing arguments now predominantly highlight Bolivia’s lithium reserves, portrayed as sufficiently abundant to meet global demand, a narrative that enhances Bolivia’s strategic importance on the world stage.

Social arguments follow patterns similar to 2005, though equity (0.36%) sees a modest increase, tied to references to redistributive policies such as the *Bono Juancito Pinto*, *Renta Dignidad*, and *Bono Juana Azurduy*, which are credited to revenues from extractive activities.

Regarding the environmental theme, the 2009 programme introduces a new category “environmentally beneficial”, linking extraction to climate change mitigation. This is tied to the proposed industrialisation of lithium, with MAS arguing that lithium development will reduce dependence on petroleum and lower GHG emissions. However, this justification appears only twice, accounting for 0.07% of the text. In parallel, the environmental responsibility (0.36%) argument related to hydrocarbons more than doubles compared to the 2005 manifesto, reflecting a better integration of environmental concerns within the extractive agenda.

5.3.3 Environmental content

Overall, the environment is framed in a way that is more integrated into MAS’s national development plans compared to 2005. The document acknowledges environmental risks of extraction but asserts that with proper state control, extractive activities can be compatible with sustainability. The main rhetorical strategy is to promote a model of *industrialización con responsabilidad ambiental* (industrialisation with environmental responsibility), which seeks to overcome the traditional extractivist model by adding value through industrial transformation while minimising environmental harm. Specifically, the programme introduces the idea of a “sustainable mining-metal industry” and promises to develop the mining sector in a way that respects environmental norms and social responsibility. Nonetheless, the narrative largely presents environmental concerns as secondary to the state-led goal of economic sovereignty and industrial progress. Additionally, MAS introduces the *Diplomacia de los Pueblos*, highlighting harmony with nature as central to its foreign policy.

The environmental section itself spans just two of the programme’s 156 pages, with additional sparse references to ecology throughout different sections. This section promotes an “Agroecological Bolivia in balance with Mother Earth” based on the principles of food sovereignty and environmental sustainability. In total, the environmental theme accounts for 1.58% of the text, compared to 8.05% dedicated to extraction.

5.4 MAS 2014 Manifesto

5.4.1 2010-2014 context

Following the 2009 elections, the MAS government continued deepening its model of resource nationalism, with the extractive industry remaining central to its development strategy (Aresti, 2016). Building on the revenue increases achieved through the nationalisation of gas and oil sectors, the implementation of the IDH and high global commodity prices, the government continued funding expansive social programmes that had already made major strides in reducing poverty and inequality (Aresti, 2016). According to an ILO (2016) report, poverty rates fell from 59% in 2005 to 39% in 2014, and the Gini index from 0.6 to 0.47 within the same period. Overall, Bolivia's macroeconomic strength during this period was unprecedented, recording one of the highest economic growths globally during the 2008-2009 global financial crisis. By 2012, the real GDP growth rate reached 5%. Additionally, the country amassed international reserves totalling \$14 billion by early 2013, nearly half of its GDP, while maintaining low inflation and reducing external debt (Farthing and Kohl, 2014).

Meanwhile, the constitutional reforms ratified in 2009 began to materialise in policy and legislation, especially in areas concerning Indigenous rights, territorial autonomy and state control over natural resources. However, the contradictions between extractive development and Indigenous rights soon came to the forefront. The most emblematic case was the TIPNIS (Territorio Indígena y Parque Nacional Isiboro Sécore) conflict, which erupted in 2011 when the government proposed the construction of a highway through Indigenous territory, arguing that it would integrate remote regions and facilitate hydrocarbon exploration. Indigenous communities, environmental groups and civil society organisations protested, viewing the project as a violation of constitutional guarantees such as prior and informed consultation, Indigenous self-determination, and as a threat to the local ecosystems. A march of about 800 Indigenous people travelled to La Paz to protest, experiencing severe police repression. Under pressure, the government passed Law 180 banning the road, but this also prohibited economic activity in the park, harming local livelihoods. A pro-road counter-march and a contested consultation process followed in 2012, with the government claiming that a majority of TIPNIS communities supported the road. Critics, however, denounced the consultation as illegitimate and coercive. Ultimately, Morales postponed construction project until after the 2014 elections (Farthing and Kohl, 2014).

On the international stage, Morales projected Bolivia as a leader in climate justice. In April 2010, he convened the People's World Conference on Climate Change and the Rights of Mother Earth (also called the People's Summit) as a grassroots alternative to the failed climate negotiations in Copenhagen, rejecting elite-driven, exclusionary climate summits. The resulting "People's Agreement of Cochabamba" called for a Universal Declaration on the Rights of Mother Earth, an international climate justice tribunal, acknowledgment of climate debt by industrialised nations, and a global referendum on environmental policy. While the event elevated Bolivia's global standing, it also revealed internal contradictions. Domestic movements such as Mesa 18 used the platform to criticise the government's reliance on extraction (Aguirre & Cooper, 2010; Dearing, 2023).

These contradictions were further highlighted when the MAS government passed two environmental laws echoing the summit's principles: the Law of the Rights of Mother Earth (Law 071, 2010) and the Framework Law for Integral Development to Live Well (Law 300, 2012). Both laws enshrined nature's legal personhood and affirmed an indigenous, ecocentric vision. However, their real-world impact has been limited. As Villavicencio Calzadilla and Kotzé (2018) argue, ongoing extractive activity, weak enforcement, and the failure to establish key institutions like the Mother Earth Ombudsman illustrate the disconnect between rhetorical commitments and policy implementation.

Despite growing tensions between environmental ideals and extractive realities, MAS entered the 2014 elections from a position of strength. Buoyed by economic success and broad support, Morales was re-elected with 61.36% of the vote. The MAS party also secured a two-thirds majority in both chambers of the Legislative Assembly, consolidating its political power³.

5.4.2 Content analysis

The 2014 MAS-IPSP government programme, titled "*Juntos vamos bien para Vivir Bien*" ("Together we are going well to Living Well"), is structured in three main sections. It begins with *La Bolivia que nos dejaron* ("The Bolivia they left us"), a retrospective critique of the neoliberal era; continues with *La Bolivia de hoy* ("Today's Bolivia"), highlighting the accomplishments of the two preceding MAS administrations; and culminates in *La Bolivia que queremos* ("The Bolivia we want"), which outlines twelve strategic policy proposals to build a

³ Tribunal Supremo Electoral. (n.d.). *Resultados elecciones generales 2014*. <https://www.oep.org.bo/procesos-electorales-y-consultas/elecciones-generales/elecciones-generales-2014-2/>

dignified, sovereign, productive, and democratic Bolivia, oriented toward the principle of *Vivir Bien*.

MAS introduces the *Modelo Económico Social Comunitario Productivo* (MESCP) as the central economic framework guiding the party’s vision for Bolivia’s transformation, and as structural alternative to neoliberalism. The model is described as social, for promoting the distribution and redistribution of wealth to eradicate poverty and reduce inequality; communitarian, for balancing individual and collective interests inspired by *Vivir Bien* and Indigenous values; and productive, for aiming to diversify the economy, overcome the primary-export model, and industrialise natural resources in harmony with nature. Its fundamental logic relies on the exploitation of natural resources and the state’s appropriation of economic surplus for redistribution.

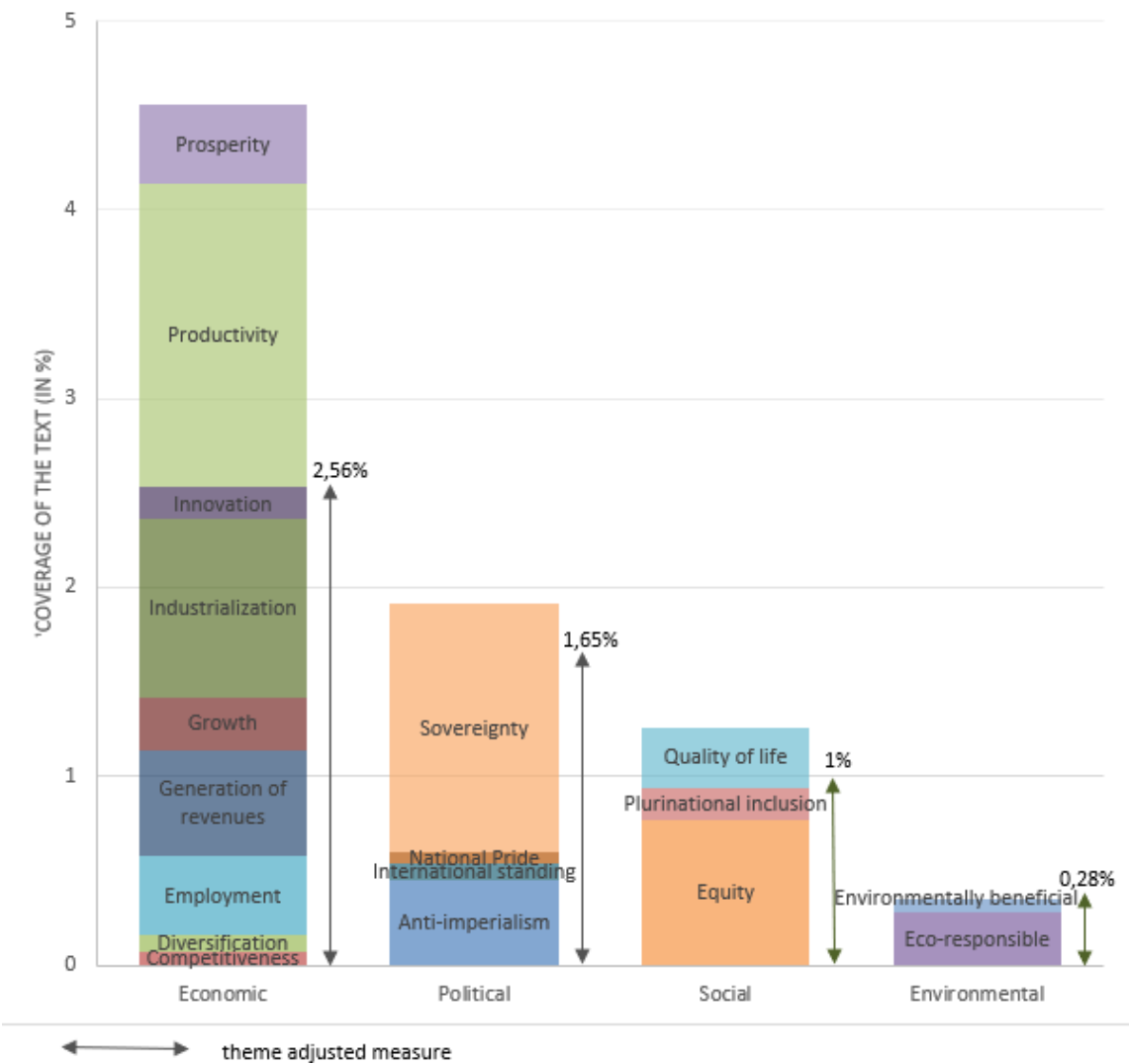


Figure 3: justifications’ repartition of the 2014 MAS government programme

Overall, economic justifications continue to dominate the programme's rhetoric, with productivity and industrialisation accounting for 1.61% and 0.94% respectively. This time, productivity clearly overrides the industrialisation argument, as increased production is more often addressed than industrialisation. For the rest of the economic justifications, they follow similar patterns to the 2009 manifesto. The programme stresses that resource extraction developments through increased production and industrialisation will drive economic growth (0.28%), diversification (0.09%), and generate revenues (0.56%) that can boost employment (0.42%) and prosperity/security (0.42%). The programme details once again extensive production and industrialisation plans, including petrochemical and metallurgical complexes, zinc and steel plants and lithium-based production to realise these economic goals. These projects are additionally framed as vehicles for increased productivity, technological innovation (0.17%), and competitiveness (0.07%).

We observe a rebound in the political-nationalist justifications to legitimise extractive activities. Sovereignty rises to 1.31% coverage and anti-imperialism to 0.45%, celebrating the reclaiming of natural resources from foreign hands as a restoration of Bolivia's sovereignty and dignity. In contrast, national pride (0.06%) and international standing (0.09%) arguments are almost absent, with only one slight reference each. It is remarkable that lithium industrialisation is not presented as a way out for international standing anymore. Moreover, there is no more mention of the role of lithium in mitigating climate change, outlined by the absence of the "environmentally beneficial" argument. Lithium is purely referred to through industrialisation, productivity and innovation justifications. At the same time, eco-responsibility arguments decrease from 0.43% in 2009 to 0.28% in 2014.

Social justifications are more explicitly connected to the revenues generated by the extractive sector than in prior programmes, in particular through the definition of the MESCP that presents the economic model reliant on the extractive sector as explicitly social. Equity (0.77%) gains visibility while quality of life (0.17%) and inclusivity (0.17%) remain consistent with earlier documents.

5.4.3 Environmental content

The programme's rhetoric continues suggesting that extraction and environmental stewardship are not inherently contradictory, provided that the state exercises control. It promotes the integrated and sustainable management of natural resources, presenting the national

development model as the “antithesis of the resource curse theory”. In this view, Bolivia’s vast reserves of minerals, hydrocarbons, and lithium are not a source of dependency or ecological risk, but rather a national blessing to be harnessed “in harmony with Mother Earth”, following the *Vivir Bien* principle. Additionally, MAS strongly reaffirms its commitment to the *Vivir Bien* philosophy, dedicating two entire sections to the topic. The philosophy is presented as Bolivia’s *horizonte civilizatorio alternativo* (Alternative civilizational horizon) to capitalism. Moreover, *Vivir Bien* is central to MAS foreign policy, which proposes to the international community the construction of a new world order based on harmony between nations and peoples globally, in order to eradicate common evils that threaten humanity and Mother Earth (hunger, disease, violence, etc.). Lastly, the document further highlights reforestation initiatives, biodiversity protection, and climate adaptation programmes, though these are framed not as constraints on extractive development, but as complementary measures.

Most strikingly, the traditional dominance of extractive discourse appears nearly balanced by environmental considerations: while the extractive theme now covers only 3.26% of the text, a significant decline from previous manifestos, the environmental theme reaches 3.11%, more than doubling its share from 2009.

5.5 MAS 2019 Manifesto

5.5.1 2015-2019 context

By 2019, the hydrocarbon sector, once a cornerstone of Bolivia's economy, faced significant challenges. After peaking in 2013, natural gas production declined and demand from key markets like Argentina and Brazil decreased. The value of gas exports dropped from \$3 billion in 2018 to \$2.7 billion in 2019. In response, the state-owned company YPFB intensified exploration efforts and investment in new infrastructure to boost production (Fong-Sam, 2023). In the search for new oil and gas reserves, the government opened protected areas where extractive activities were previously strictly prohibited, such as the Tariquía reserve, sparking protests from local communities concerned about environmental degradation and denouncing lack of prior consultation (Graham, T., 2024).

On the side of Bolivia’s lithium industry, a small-scale pilot lithium carbonate plant with limited operations had been launched by 2013. A new push came in 2018 with the inauguration of an industrial-scale potassium chloride plant and the signing of a joint venture between the state-

owned company *Yacimientos de Litio Bolivianos* (YLB) and the German firm ACI Systems to build a lithium hydroxide plant and battery production facilities. Despite initially rejecting foreign investment, YLB ended up shifting toward external collaboration. However, concerns over environmental harm and inequitable benefit-sharing led to public outcry and the eventual cancellation of the deal in late 2019 (Sanchez-Lopez, 2019), though later resumed in modified form (Janubová, 2023; Obaya, 2021). By 2019, Bolivia reached its highest pilot production of lithium carbonate at 421 metric tons. Although Bolivia possesses the world's largest deposit, the country has not extracted lithium at industrial scale yet, in contrast to Chile and Argentina, the country's neighbours of the Lithium Triangle, which have been extracting and exporting lithium for more than 20 years (Janubová, 2023).

These economic tensions coincided with growing political unrest. The 2009 Constitution limits presidents to one re-election, making Morales ineligible for a fourth term (the first term is not considered). Yet MAS pushed for a constitutional amendment to permit another term through national referendum. Although this was defeated with 51.3% voting against Morales' eligibility and 48.7% in favour, Bolivia's Constitutional Court ruled that re-election was a human right under the American Convention on Human Rights, thereby annulling limits on term renewal. This controversial decision ignited a strong reaction from opposition groups and urban middle classes, who accused Morales of undermining democratic norms.

The 2019 election, which Morales won with 47.08% of the vote, sparked immediate unrest. Suspicion mounted after the electoral authority halted the quick count at 83.8% and reconvened with a surprising upward shift in Morales' favour. Accusations of fraud supported by the Organization of American States (OAS) audit triggered mass protests nationwide. The unrest intensified as police units began to mutiny, and the Armed Forces suggested that President Morales step down. On November 10, 2019, amid massive mobilisations and collapsing institutional support, Morales resigned and fled into exile, bringing a dramatic end to his 13-year rule (Cunha Filho, 2023).

5.5.2. Content analysis

The 2019 government programme, titled *Agenda del Pueblo para el Bicentenario* (The People's Agenda for the Bicentennial), delineates a comprehensive vision for Bolivia's national development as the country approaches its bicentennial in 2025. Reflecting a participatory methodology for its drafting, the programme is articulated around 13 foundational pillars and

five strategic axes: economic consolidation, social inclusion, dignified employment, security and justice, and sustainable development. It further builds on the MESCP introduced in the former manifesto, reinforcing a state-led model of development that aspires to combine industrial advancement with social justice and ecological consciousness.

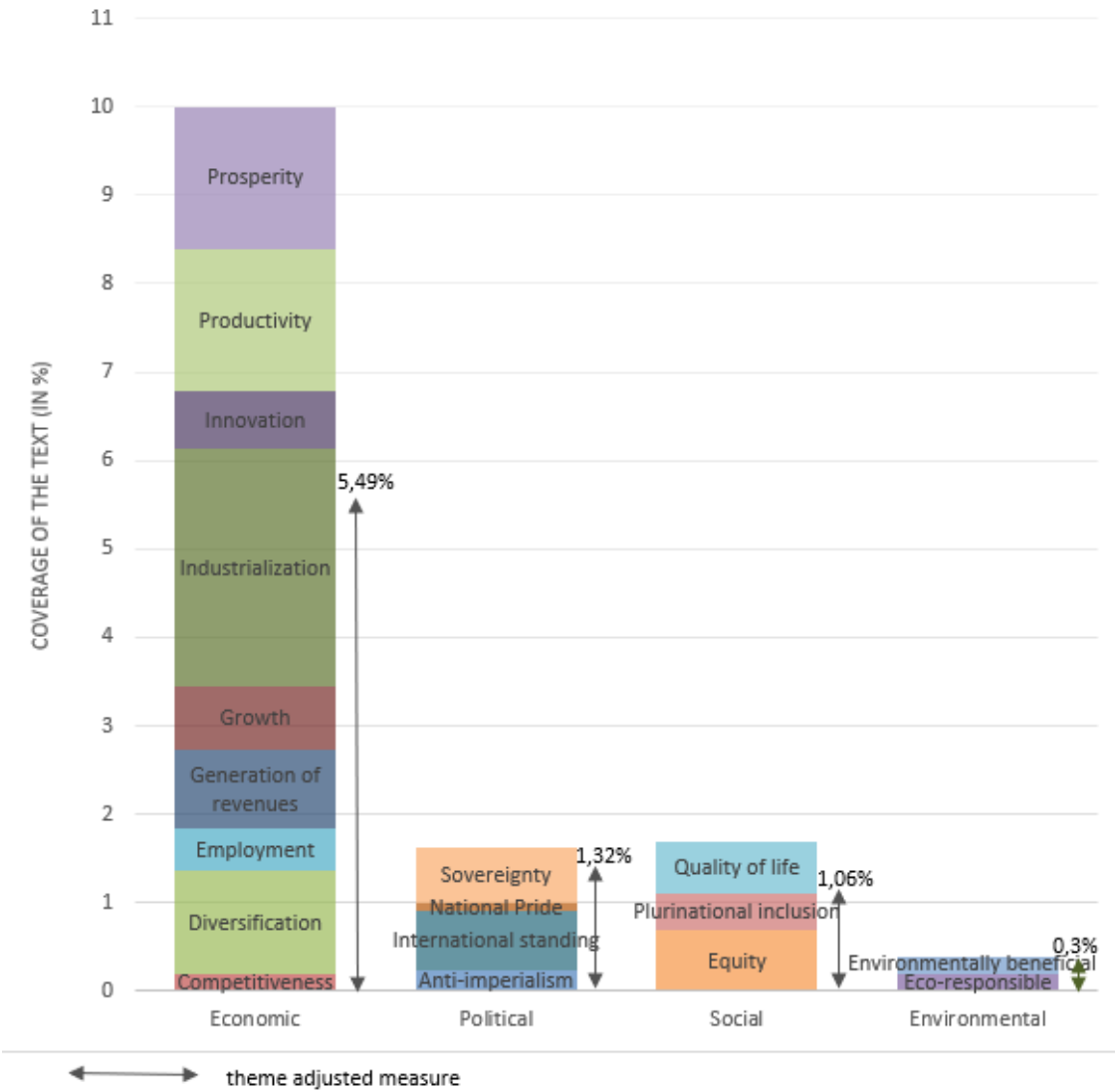


Figure 4: justifications' repartition of the 2019 MAS government programme

Industrialisation (2.68%) stands out clearly as the dominant justification, as the party underlines the importance of transforming Bolivia from a raw material exporter into an industrial producer with higher value-added outputs (selective industrialisation). Similarly, the party places heightened emphasis on economic diversification (1.16%) and innovation/technology (0.65%) justifications, presenting extraction as a tool to mitigate the effects of global economic volatility. The unfavourable international context, characterised by declining commodity prices, fluctuating capital flows, and commercial and geopolitical tensions, is leveraged by MAS to underline the urgency of deepening the country’s model of resource-based

industrialisation, thereby reducing dependency on raw commodity exports and enhancing domestic value chains. While this strategy generally applies to hydrocarbons, the industrialisation plans for lithium also present the ambition of ascending the global value chain through the production of lithium-ion batteries and associated technologies. This vision is to be achieved through mixed ownership models that preserve state sovereignty while attracting foreign capital and technological expertise. Consistently with the precarious global context depicted by MAS, the economic prosperity/security (1.05%) justification experienced a remarkable increase compared to previous manifestos. Productivity (1.62%), generation of revenues (0.89%) and employment (0.48%) justifications remain consistent with the previous manifesto, being most often related to the MESCP. Meanwhile, references to the role of extraction in driving growth (0.72%), and competitiveness (0.2%) have slightly increased, with no notable shifts in content.

Among political justifications, the most marked increase is in international standing, now accounting for 0.67% (up from 0.09% in 2015), whereas national pride remains low (0.09%). The rise in international standing justifications is primarily attributed to the importance given to lithium in the economic narrative of the manifesto. As MAS declares: *“Ninguna otra propuesta podrá preparar mejor a Bolivia para su Bicentenario y para afrontar el siglo XXI (...)”* (No other proposal can better prepare Bolivia for its Bicentennial and for facing the 21st century (...)). In contrast, references to sovereignty (0.62%) and anti-imperialism (0.24%) justifications have significantly declined, appearing mostly in retrospective accounts of past MAS achievements.

On the social front, references to equity (0.69%) and quality of life (0.59%) remain stable. Notably, quality of life is increasingly framed in relation to the adverse and unpredictable international context. Inclusivity shows a noticeable rise (0.41%), although mentions of “inclusive development” linked to extraction lack concrete policy proposals.

The environmentally beneficial argument accounts for 0.2% of the text, equalling the eco-responsibility argument for the first time. In particular, MAS presents lithium industrialisation as an opportunity to innovate within the extractive sector, rendering the current economic model sustainable, and contributing to the global energy transition away from fossil fuels.

5.5.3. Environmental content

The programme's engagement with environmental issues and climate change is articulated as the fourth strategic axe and through Pillar 9: *Soberanía ambiental con desarrollo integral* (Environmental sovereignty with integral development). Environmental sovereignty is defined as achieving national development while respecting the rights of Mother Earth, consolidating the integration of the environmental agenda within a developmentalist paradigm, although priority is given to the intensification of resource extraction and industrialisation. Environmental stewardship is reaffirmed as a normative commitment, anchored in the Andean cosmovision of “*Madre Tierra*”. Moreover, MAS further entrenches its environmental diplomacy, outlining its key contributions such as to the UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples. MAS commits to consolidate the diplomacy of the Peoples and of the *Vivir Bien*, as well as the international recognition of the rights of Mother Earth.

In particular, the document explicitly acknowledges the ecological externalities of extractive and urban expansion, including pollution, biodiversity loss, and contamination, outlining the urgency to address them. It commits to a range of mitigation and adaptation strategies, such as risk management for climate change, investment in water resources, and stricter regulation against wildlife trafficking. However, rather than placing ecological limits on extractive activities, the programme advocates for a model of “sustainable extraction” wherein technological modernisation and regulatory oversight are expected to reconcile economic growth with environmental responsibility. In total, environmental coverage accounts for 2.47%, while extractive coverage accounts for 4.45%

5.6 MAS 2020 Manifesto

5.6.1 2019-2020 context

After Evo Morales resigned on November 10, 2019, Bolivia entered a period of deep political crisis marked by institutional uncertainty, polarisation, and repression. With all constitutional successors stepping down, Jeanine Áñez, a little-known senator and second vice-president of the Senate, assumed the presidency on November 12, 2019. Though her accession was controversial and arguably irregular, the Plurinational Constitutional Court endorsed it as a transitional measure to call new elections. However, Áñez's transitional government quickly moved beyond this limited role, adopting a starkly anti-MAS stance, initiating judicial

proceedings against former MAS officials, and reversing symbolic and policy decisions of the Morales era. Her administration's tone was marked by conservative, even reactionary rhetoric, including racist depictions of indigenous and rural populations. The government also militarised public order and cracked down violently on MAS supporters, most infamously in the Sacaba and Senkata massacres, where security forces killed dozens of protesters. These actions, along with Áñez's later announcement of her own presidential candidacy in January 2020, undermined the neutrality expected of a caretaker government and fractured the anti-MAS bloc that had coalesced after Morales's fall (Cunha Filho, 2023).

The transitional period was further prolonged by the COVID-19 pandemic, which became the justification for repeatedly postponing elections initially scheduled for March 2020. Amid mounting public pressure, protests, and widespread blockades, elections were finally held on October 18. MAS, now led by Luis Arce and David Choquehuanca as presidential and vice-presidential candidates respectively, maintained its extensive grassroots organisational strength and capitalised on widespread discontent with the Áñez government and a fragmented opposition. The result was a decisive MAS victory in the first round, with Arce winning 55.1% of votes, more than double that of the runner-up, Carlos Mesa, marking the party's swift return to power (Cunha Filho, 2023).

5.6.2 Content analysis

Regarding the candidate shift within the MAS party for the 2020 election, we expected notable changes in the party's rhetoric throughout the 2020 manifesto. This was reflected in our hypothesis H4: "The transition from Evo Morales to Luis Arce as the leader of MAS has been accompanied by a discursive shift regarding extractivism and environmentalism."

However, the 2020 manifesto appears to be almost identical to the 2019 manifesto, refuting our hypothesis as of now. From the title to the structure and the images, almost nothing has changed. A section denouncing the "golpe de Estado" (coup) and the return to neoliberalism under the interim government was added, positioning MAS as the only political force capable of restoring economic growth, social stability, and plurinational democracy. Moreover, paragraphs were added or removed here and there, slightly modifying the coding. We still decided to conduct a coding to verify there were no substantial changes, but obtained almost the same graph. We will then refer to the content of the 2019 and the 2020 manifestos as being the same.

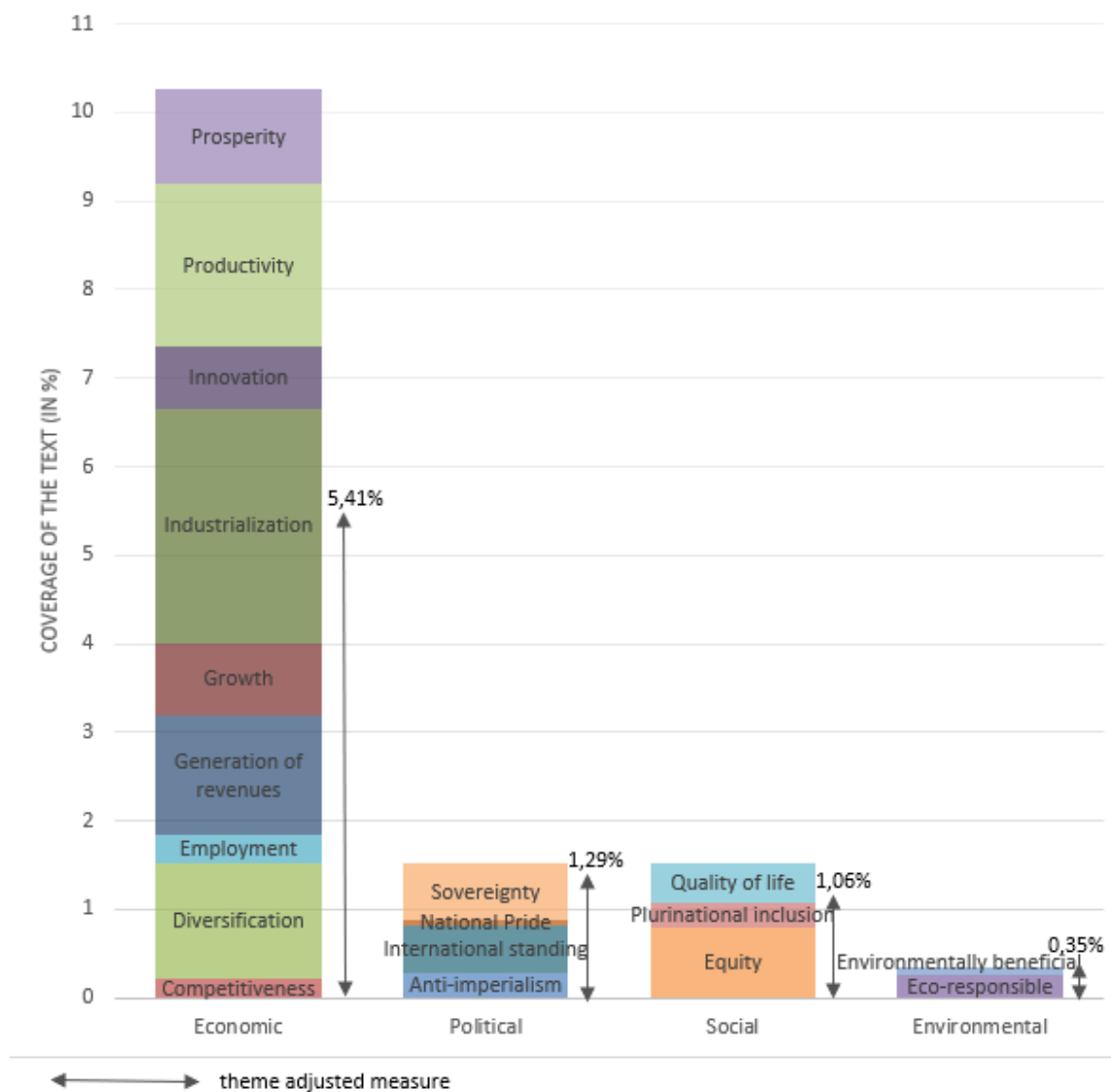


Figure 5: justifications' repartition of the 2020 MAS government programme

6 LONGITUDINAL ANALYSIS

6.1 The evolution of MAS's framing of the extractive sector

Based on the results presented in the previous section, we will now discuss how the ways in which MAS justifies its reliance on the extractive sector has evolved across mandates, and in relation to their contexts. To facilitate our longitudinal reading, we will discuss the evolutions and shifts noticed theme after theme and situate them in the related contexts. For statistical coherence, we will now use the adjusted measures. A table presenting the adjusted coverage percentages of all five manifestos' themes is available in Annex B. As a reminder, because entire sentences were coded, they were sometimes coded in multiple subcodes of the same theme, contributing to an overrepresentation of the coverage per theme. To overcome this bias, we withdrew repeated sentences from each theme, resulting in the 'theme adjusted measure'. Although the results are different, they follow the exact same patterns over prominence and evolution as when not adjusted.

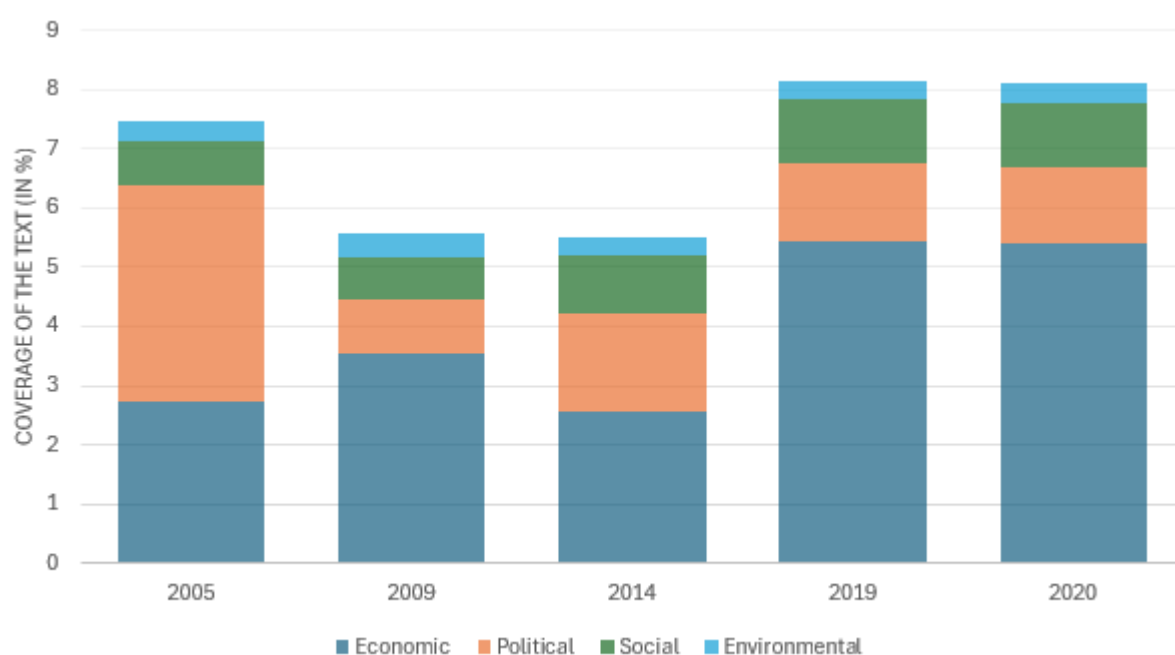


Figure 6: thematic repartition of the justifications across manifestos

Political justifications

While resource extraction was primarily justified in political terms within the 2005 party programme, it became a secondary argument to all four next manifestos, overridden by

economic justifications. Overall, political justifications for extraction show a clear trajectory from strong nationalist rhetoric to a more subdued, instrumental approach.

In 2005, MAS framed extraction, particularly of hydrocarbons, as an act of reclaiming national sovereignty and resisting imperialism. Sovereignty and anti-imperialism dominated the discursive space. Extraction was deeply politicised, rooted in a narrative of restoring Bolivia's dignity and asserting control over its natural wealth. The strong nationalist framing of extraction in the 2005 manifesto is best understood in the wake of Bolivia's explosive rejection of neoliberalism. Coming after two decades of privatisation, violent conflicts like the Gas War, and the rise of grassroots Indigenous mobilisation, MAS capitalised on a powerful anti-imperialist moment.

By 2009, this tone had softened and sovereignty and anti-imperialism both markedly declined in textual prominence. MAS was no longer an oppositional force but a ruling party consolidating its power. In particular, the word sovereignty was reframed less as a political ideal and more as economic self-reliance, shifting toward control over revenues, thereby leaving the political code. Moreover, the international standing arguments gained prominence due to MAS's plans to industrialise lithium, starting to position Bolivia less as a victim of imperialism and more as a proactive global player. Overall, the political justification was less a moral imperative and more a functional requirement for state-led development.

In 2014, sovereignty resurged as MAS put the emphasis on its past achievements in nationalising key sectors, framing this as a victory over foreign exploitation. This can potentially be linked to domestic tensions, especially the TIPNIS conflict, as criticisms from indigenous groups threatened MAS's legitimacy, prompting a reaffirmation of its original political values. Anti-imperialism also saw a minor rebound, though national pride and international standing receded. In particular, lithium industrialisation was purely referred to in economic terms, not as source of international standing.

By 2019 and 2020, sovereignty and anti-imperialism were largely retrospective, used to recount past successes. This suggests another rhetorical shift: from 2009 on, political arguments were more and more celebratory rather than mobilising, legitimising past decisions rather than justifying future ones. On the other side, in the face of economic slowdown, the political framing moved toward aspirational nationalism instead, and international standing emerged as the dominant political frame. In particular, lithium was framed as a vehicle for Bolivia's ascent

on the global stage and as a 21st century leader, reinforcing the shift from anti-colonial defiance to geopolitical strategy.

Overall, national pride justifications, mostly referred to as national dignity, have slightly declined over the mandates, supposedly because MAS claimed that their dignity had been restored with 2006 nationalisation.

Economic justifications

Except for the 2005 manifesto, economic arguments consistently dominate MAS manifestos, but their internal composition and narrative logic have evolved markedly.

In 2005, productivity and industrialisation were the cornerstones of economic discourse, closely tied to building a “productive matrix” as a post-neoliberal development model. Extraction was justified as the foundation of state-led economic reconstruction, with growth and employment framed as secondary outcomes.

With the 2009 manifesto, MAS had already reaped the fiscal benefits of its nationalisations, and the generation of revenues/surpluses for the state emerged as a new justification for extraction. The context of strong GDP growth, booming gas exports, and rising state revenues allowed the party to pivot toward more expansive industrial ambitions. Industrialisation became the leading economic argument, though productivity remained central and new frames emerged, like diversification, innovation and prosperity, reflecting the confidence of a government that had both political dominance and resource windfalls.

The 2014 manifesto slightly recalibrated this balance. With the introduction of the MESCP as economic model, productivity remained central, but industrialisation decreased slightly. Instead, prosperity/security and employment gained weight, suggesting a desire to reassure voters about the long-term sustainability of the extractive path. Innovation and diversification remained marginal. Notably, economic justifications were increasingly tied to concrete and more technocratic projects (e.g., petrochemical plants, lithium factories), mirroring the institutional maturity of the MAS state project.

By 2019–2020, with commodity prices falling and regional demand for gas shrinking, MAS’s extractive rhetoric hardened into urgency. Industrialisation and diversification surged, and extraction was redefined as essential not only for growth but primarily for economic prosperity/security and resilience in an unstable world. Extraction was no longer simply a

developmental tool, but an indispensable path to high-value, technology-driven autonomy in a volatile global economy. The economic discourse became more forward-looking, emphasising global value chains and selective modernisation.

Social justifications

Social justifications have been increasingly emphasised, though minor compared to economic and political ones. In 2005, MAS framed quality of life and equity as moral imperatives behind extraction. These justifications were broad and aspirational, tied to promises of universal welfare and reversing neoliberal harm. Although inclusion was not framed in relation to extraction, it was central to MAS's rhetoric and promise to reverse decades of exclusion, reflecting its foundational alliance with marginalised Indigenous and rural population.

By 2009, equity gained prominence, backed by concrete redistributive measures funded by extractive revenues such as the Juancito Pinto and Renta Dignidad programmes that had been implemented during the first mandate, and that needed to consolidate. Quality of life remained consistent, while inclusion appeared modestly. Extraction began to be positioned as the enabler of visible social transformation.

In 2014, amid both economic strength and emerging societal tensions, and with the introduction of the MESCP, equity was emphasised more explicitly, while quality of life and inclusivity remained stable.

In 2019 and 2020, with mounting political unrest and economic uncertainty, the share of social justifications subtly rose, and their content evolved to a form of reaffirmation of extraction as a lifeline. In particular, inclusivity saw a marked increase. However, the rhetoric of “inclusive development” was most often not backed by specific policies. In general, we observed that inclusion was loosely coupled, or not at all, with the extractive agenda.

Environmental justifications

Environmental justifications have shown the most modest coverages across all mandates, but also the most mixed evolution, alternating between minimising, instrumentalising, and reviving to align with narratives around the extractive economic model.

In the 2005 manifesto, environmental justifications were marginal, shyly framing MAS extraction model as ecologically responsible and future-oriented (sustainable). This framing functioned as a normative gesture rather than a core element of extractive policy. Overall, the

section dedicated to the environment was distinctly separated from the narratives around the state's economic model and the reliance on the extractive sector. In particular, MAS committed not to permit hydrocarbon or mining exploitation in protected areas, which is the only measure constraining extraction from all manifestos.

By 2009, environmental responsibility discourses doubled, while a new framing emerged with the introduction of the 'environmentally beneficial' category. Through the case of lithium, extraction was not just framed as eco-responsible but as actively contributing to mitigate climate change, notably by reducing fossil fuel dependence through lithium-based technologies. More globally, MAS reframed environmental care as compatible with state-led industrialisation reliant on extraction, promoted by statements such as "industrialisation with environmental responsibility". While environmental risks and constraints of extraction were acknowledged, notably through the denunciation of previous neoliberal extractivism, MAS would assert that, with proper state control, their economic model could be respectful toward the environment, in particular through shifting from exporting raw material to exporting value-added products through industrial transformation. However, these industrialisation plans were most often coupled with extended exploitation plans of extractive resources. While more emphasised than in the 2005 manifesto, environmental arguments remained limited in scope and were largely employed to harmonise continued extractive practices with the new ecocentric and pluricultural constitutional framework, including the constitutional recognition of *Vivir Bien*.

In 2014, references to the environmental benefits of lithium disappeared entirely. Lithium was now framed strictly in economic terms, suggesting a retreat from earlier efforts to link extractive activities with ecological transition. The absence of the environmentally beneficial framing in this manifesto is striking and somewhat enigmatic. One possible explanation lies in the heightened internal scrutiny Bolivia faced at that time, particularly from environmental groups and actors. Following the People's Summit on Climate Change and the Rights of Mother Earth, which positioned Bolivia as a global leader in climate justice, and the enactment of groundbreaking environmental laws, the contradictions inherent in MAS's extractive-led development model became increasingly visible and criticised. Simultaneously, internal dissent over extractive projects, most notably the TIPNIS conflict and mobilisations by groups like Mesa 18 exposed these contradictions even more. In this context, it is plausible that the party deliberately tempered its environmental rhetoric, avoiding framings that could be perceived as hypocritical or contradictory. On the other side, the programme's rhetoric continues suggesting

that extraction and environmental responsibility are not inherently contradictory, provided that the state exercises control. A novel narrative emerges as MAS refers to its development model as “the antithesis of the resource curse theory”, presenting Bolivia’s resource wealth as a blessing to be harnessed in harmony with Mother Earth, rather than a source of dependency or ecological risk.

The environmentally beneficial argument forcefully resurged in 2019, this time equalling the eco-responsibility justification. Lithium extraction was again presented as a cornerstone of Bolivia’s contribution to the global energy transition, offering a pathway to a “sustainable” economic model grounded in green technology. This renewed emphasis can possibly be understood as a response to increasing global interest in “green” minerals. It also coincides with efforts to reposition Bolivia as a strategic player in the international climate arena, despite ongoing tensions over environmental governance and public resistance to extractive projects in protected areas. Besides, the programme consolidates the integration of environmental concerns within the extractive agenda under the name of “environmental sovereignty”, described by MAS as achieving national development while respecting the rights of Mother Earth. The document also explicitly acknowledges the ecological externalities of extractive expansion and outlines the urgency of addressing those. However, rather than placing ecological limits on extractive activities, it commits to a range of mitigation and adaptation strategies.

Overall, the evolution reflects a discursive balancing act: as MAS consolidated power, it sought to reconcile extractivism with environmentalism through the logic of state-led sustainability, preserving its ecological commitments rhetorically while maintaining extractive practices as central to its economic model. This echoes Botero and Galeano’s (2017) argument that Bolivia is struggling to reconcile its progressive constitutional ideals with the practical demands of an extractive-based economy. Thereby, except in the 2005 manifesto, environmental care was never framed as a brake on extraction but rather as its conditional partner. This dynamic is referred to by Anthias (2018) as “Hydrocarbon Citizenship”, where the priority given to hydrocarbon extraction (in this case, extraction in general) makes it the motor behind all government policies.

All in all, this focus on the environmental types of justification for extraction allows us to verify one more hypothesis (H1), confirming that MAS employs discursive strategies that fit within Green Extractivism. However, it is also important to underline that these justifications are minor

compared to other types of justifications, and clearly not central to MAS’s discursive strategies to justify extraction, although strategically mobilised with consistency across mandates.

Lastly, and more globally, another hypothesis (H2) has been verified throughout the entire longitudinal section, confirming that the MAS’s framings of the extractive sector have evolved over time and across different mandates, and considerably.

6.2 Extraction versus the Environment

An additional coding process was carried out to compare the percentage coverage of the extractive theme with that of the environmental theme, accompanied by a qualitative examination of the environmental content, included in the previous “Results” section. We now refer to the global themes, not limited to framings or justifications. The figure below illustrates the evolution of coverage for both themes across manifestos. A table presenting the coverage percentages of both themes in all manifestos is available in Annex C. A linear trend line has been included to highlight the tendency trajectories over time.

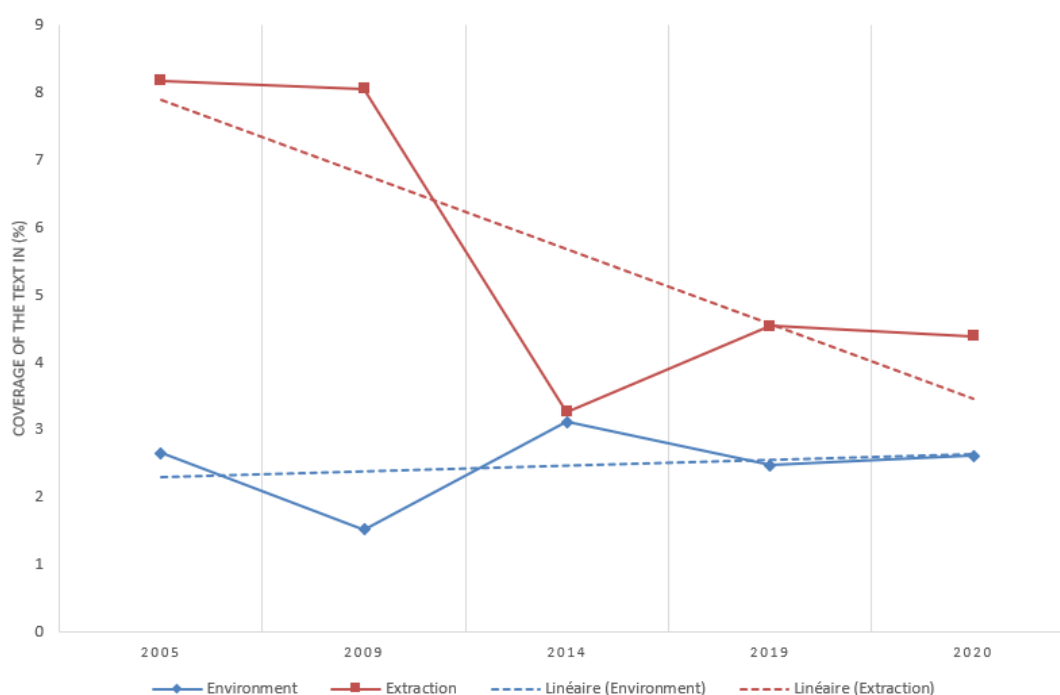


Figure 7: prominence of the extractive and environmental themes

While already supported by the previous section on environmental justifications, this figure reinforces hypothesis H3, according to which MAS consistently puts greater emphasis on extractive activities and the economy rather than ecology and the environment. However, the gap between the coverage of both themes considerably changes from manifesto to manifesto,

with an overall declining tendency. While the coverage of extraction was the highest in 2005 and 2009, it declined considerably in 2014, almost reaching the level of environmental coverage, then heightened again in 2019. In parallel, the environmental theme was the highest in the 2005 and 2014 manifestos, reaching its lowest level in 2009 and declining again in 2019.

7 LIMITS

Although this thesis was conducted with methodological care and analytical rigour, several limitations must be acknowledged.

First, the quantitative data provided might appear somewhat confusing at first. To ensure comparability across manifestos of varying lengths, the analysis relies on percentage coverage rather than the absolute number of references. While this methodological choice was essential to avoid bias introduced by textual length differences, it also rendered the data more difficult to visualise. Nevertheless, the percentage coverage offers the additional advantage of conveying the relative prominence of each justification within the overall discourse of a given manifesto. Another confusing factor has been the conflict between representing the coverage per sub-category and per category. Because a single sentence can include multiple justifications falling under different sub-codes of the same broader theme, simply summing the coverage of all sub-codes can result in a total that exceeds the actual coverage of the parent theme. In other words, overlapping codings inflate the apparent frequency of the broader category. This presented a dilemma: either represent the sub-themes accurately and risk misrepresenting the theme-level coverage, or vice versa. Our solution to this unavoidable tension was to present both levels of data side by side. Fortunately, while the absolute values differed, both representations reflected the exact same patterns of prominence and evolution, thereby reinforcing the reliability of the findings.

Second, it is important to acknowledge that the exclusive focus on party manifestos provides only a partial view of MAS's broader rhetorical strategy. Capturing the full scope of a party's discourse would ideally require an extensive analysis of speeches, interviews, press releases, and other public communications. However, the decision to focus on manifestos was deliberate and methodologically justified. Manifestos offer a coherent and standardised format across time, making them particularly well-suited for systematic comparison and tracking discursive shifts across different political mandates. For instance, as they are designed to present a full account of a party's governance vision, omissions are analytically significant and reflect a strategic silencing or a deprioritisation. In contrast, the absence of a topic in a speech or interview often lacks such weight, as those formats are typically constrained by occasion. Furthermore, the scope of analysis was more easily definable with manifestos: it was feasible to analyse the complete set of MAS government programmes from 2005 to 2020, while

establishing a representative and manageable corpus of public discourses would have posed greater methodological and logistical challenges. Thus, while the focus on manifestos entails certain limitations, it also enables a structured and comparative approach that serves the aims of this research effectively.

Third, the word count limitations imposed on this thesis restricted the level of detail that could be dedicated to presenting and contextualising within the programmes each type of justification. Significant efforts were made to remain concise, sometimes at the expense of the analytical depth of the research. Moreover, due to the amount of results generated by the research, it appeared impossible to keep the thesis under the word limits.

Lastly, the thesis was written at a moment that precedes what may prove to be a significant rhetorical shift within MAS. The 2020 manifesto, expected to reflect changes in rhetoric due to the leadership change from Evo Morales to Luis Arce, turned out to be nearly identical to the 2019 version. This copy-pasting is understandable given that only a year separated the two documents, a year marked by political suspension under an interim government, and that the party had been unable to implement its 2019 programme. While a comparison of rhetorical strategies under Arce would be analytically valuable, the timeframe fell too short for the forthcoming 2025 document, limiting the possibility of pursuing this line of inquiry.

8 CONCLUSION

The aim of this thesis was to examine how Bolivia's Movimiento al Socialismo (MAS) strategically framed its reliance on natural resource extraction in five consecutive government manifestos (2005–2020), and how these framings evolved over time. Particular attention was paid to the environmental justifications employed by MAS, analysed through the theoretical lens of Green Extractivism.

The thesis first situated MAS's extractive strategy within broader academic debates on extractivism before introducing Green Extractivism as the central theoretical framework. Following a methodological overview, the empirical findings were presented chronologically (manifesto by manifesto) and subsequently assessed through a longitudinal analysis to identify discursive trends and shifts over time.

The central research question was: *“How does the MAS party strategically frame its reliance on extraction to legitimise such practices, and how have these framings evolved across successive mandates?”*

The question was answered using a mixed qualitative-quantitative content analysis. Manifesto sentences that framed extractive activities in a legitimising way were systematically coded and organised in categories and sub-categories. This process facilitated the qualitative analysis of the content of MAS's justifications for extraction, while measuring the frequency of all framing types in percentage coverage. The initial grid of analysis, constructed inductively, considered economic, political, social, and environmental framing categories, while the inductive coding process allowed us to identify a large range of framing sub-categories that were integrated into the four main categories. This process generated as first result a typology revealing that MAS employed a broad repertoire of frames.

Economic justifications were the most diverse and dominant throughout all manifestos (with the exception of 2005), portraying extraction as the engine of productivity, industrialisation, national growth, diversification, revenue generation (for public investment), technological innovation, employment, prosperity, and competitiveness. While productivity and industrialisation remained the backbone of MAS's economic rhetoric, the other framings gained traction as the party's industrial ambitions expanded. By 2019, amidst declining commodity prices and reduced gas exports, economic framing took on a more urgent and future-oriented

tone, emphasising selective industrialisation and integration into global value chains alongside economic resilience/prosperity.

Alongside economics, MAS frequently invokes political framings to justify extraction, mobilising state sovereignty, anti-imperialism (resisting foreign domination and exploitation), international standing (positioning Bolivia as a global actor) and national pride as arguments. While sovereignty and anti-imperialism were particularly salient in the 2005 manifesto, these narratives softened after 2009, becoming more celebratory and backward-looking. Meanwhile, the argument of international standing grew in importance, especially by 2019 in the face of economic slowdown, as lithium was positioned as Bolivia's most strategic resource to global relevance.

Social framings, though less prominent, were consistent across all manifestos. Extraction was portrayed as a tool for enhancing quality of life, promoting equity through redistribution, and less often for fostering inclusion. These narratives were mainly used to support MAS's self-image as a redistributive and inclusive force rooted in social justice.

Crucially, the research found that environmental justifications, while constituting the smallest portion of the legitimising discourse, were systematically mobilised. Two main types emerged. The first one portrays extraction, particularly of lithium, as environmentally beneficial, contributing to sustainability and climate change mitigation. This framing appeared in 2009 with the introduction of MAS's lithium industrialisation plans and became particularly salient in the 2019-2020 manifestos, coinciding with the rise of lithium industrialisation as a development priority in the face of economic slowdown and increasing global interest in "green" minerals. The second type depicts extractive activities as environmentally responsible, asserting that the state-led industrialisation model reliant on resource extraction is compatible with ecological stewardship and respect for Mother Earth. This compatibility was increasingly emphasised across mandates, culminating in the 2019-2020 manifestos as MAS introduced the notion of "environmental sovereignty", described as achieving national development while respecting the rights of Mother Earth. While the environmentally responsible framing allows the party not to constrain the expanding frontiers of its extractive activities, the environmentally beneficial goes beyond the compatibility narrative to present extraction (of lithium) as even beneficial and necessary for the energy transition required to mitigate climate change. According to these findings, MAS's environmental narratives around extraction clearly align with the logic of Green Extractivism, confirming our hypothesis H1. Moreover, hypothesis H2

according to which MAS's framing of the extractive sector has evolved over time and across different mandates was thoroughly confirmed throughout the entire longitudinal analysis, revealing that notable changes have occurred. However, while expecting a notable change between MAS's rhetoric under Morales in 2019 and under Arce in 2020, the 2020 manifesto appeared to be an almost identical copy of the 2019 one, refuting hypothesis H4.

In sum, MAS's legitimation strategy is multifaceted: it portrays extraction as economically necessary, politically empowering, socially beneficial and environmentally conscientious. More generally, the findings demonstrate that while MAS sought to reconcile its extractivist-based development model with its foundational environmental and plurinational commitments, the persistent and often growing emphasis on expanding the frontiers of extractive activities seems to consistently override these commitments, verifying hypothesis H3. This highlights the profound challenges that resource-dependent states face when trying to align such progressive ideas with the practical demands of a resource-based economic model.

The choice to analyse all framing types, not just environmental ones, proved essential. It allowed the study to place green justifications in proper perspective and to understand how they functioned relative to other narratives. This comprehensive approach clarified that environmental claims were often secondary and instrumental, used to reinforce rather than challenge the extractive development model. Most importantly, their share within MAS's overall justificatory arguments for extraction is marginal, accounting for only 0.18% to 0.43% of the total content in its manifestos. By way of comparison, the highest share of political justifications within a manifesto reaches 3.66%, while the economic justifications reach 5.45% coverage.

Further research could expand on these findings by incorporating a wider array of communicative materials, such as speeches and policy documents, to provide a more multifaceted view of MAS's discursive strategies. Additionally, comparative studies with other "Pink Tide" governments and/or other resource-dependent nations could also yield valuable insights into the varying manifestations and efficacies of Green Extractivist narratives. Lastly, further longitudinal analysis of MAS manifestos beyond 2020 will be crucial to track the continued evolution of these discourses, particularly in light of ongoing economic pressures and the accelerating global climate crisis. Understanding how governments navigate the complex nexus of development, resource extraction, and environmental sustainability remains a critical inquiry.

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Annex A: table of percentage coverage for all sub-categories of all government programmes

	2005	2009	2014	2019	2020
Economic					
Growth	0.7	0.27	0.28	0.72	0.82
Diversification	0	0.32	0.09	1.16	1.31
Generation of revenues	0	0.85	0.56	0.89	1.35
Productivity	1.5	1.54	1.61	1.62	1.83
Prosperity	0	0.42	0.42	1.6	1.07
Employment	0.26	0.64	0.42	0.48	0.32
Industrialisation	1.44	1.8	0.94	2.68	2.64
Innovation	0	0.38	0.17	0.65	0.71
Competitiveness	0.15	0.15	0.07	0.2	0.21
Environmental					
Eco-responsible	0.18	0.36	0.28	0.2	0.26
Environmentally beneficial	0	0.07	0.07	0.19	0.09
Political					
Anti-imperialism	2	0.17	0.45	0.24	0.27
International standing	0.29	0.2	0.09	0.67	0.54
National Pride	0.22	0.22	0.06	0.09	0.07
Sovereignty	3.02	0.48	1.31	0.62	0.64
Social					
Equity	0.21	0.36	0.77	0.69	0.79
Inclusion	0.12	0.1	0.17	0.41	0.27
Quality of life	0.53	0.36	0.32	0.59	0.47

Annex B: table of percentage coverage for all categories of all government programmes (adjusted measures)

	Economic	Political	Social	Environmental
<i>2005</i>	2.73	3.66	0.74	0.18
<i>2009</i>	3.55	0.9	0.7	0.43
<i>2014</i>	2.56	1.65	1	0.28
<i>2019</i>	5.45	1.32	1.06	0.3
<i>2020</i>	5.41	1.29	1.06	0.35

Annex C: table of percentage coverage of the extractive and environmental contents

	2005	2009	2014	2019	2020
Environment	2.65	1.52	3.11	2.47	2.61
Extraction	8.17	8.05	3.26	4.54	4.39

Annex D: information on the use of GenAI

In the context of this thesis, I have made use of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) exclusively as a writing support tool, and not as a source of information, data, or content generation. At no point was GenAI used to retrieve or create ideas, theoretical input, empirical data, or arguments. Instead, my use was limited to language enhancement: improving the clarity, academic tone, and stylistic consistency of text segments that I had already written independently, based entirely on my own research, data analysis, and conceptual understanding.

A typical prompt used during this process was as follows: *“Dear AI, can you please help me improve the writing of this text? Make it look more academic, clear, and avoid repetitive vocabulary. Work strictly on the content of the text and don't add or remove anything.”*

Furthermore, my use aligns with KU Leuven’s basic principles for the responsible use of GenAI:

- Transparency: This annex explicitly discloses the scope and nature of GenAI use.
- Verification: All GenAI-assisted edits were carefully reviewed, and no information was added or altered beyond the linguistic surface.
- Respect for data and copyright: No sensitive, copyrighted, or unpublished data was shared with external AI platforms.
- Responsibility: I remain fully responsible for the content and academic integrity of this thesis, and treated GenAI as a supplementary tool, not a content creator.

In line with KU Leuven’s emphasis on responsible innovation and academic integrity, I have ensured that GenAI was used in a manner that supports, rather than undermines, the principles of transparency, intellectual authorship, and academic honesty.